

500 Essential Words for the GRE

The list below contains 500 *essential* words that you should learn for the GRE. Do not move ahead to the *advanced* word list until you have learned these (advanced words can be found later in this appendix).

This list contains all of the words in the Manhattan Prep 500 Essential Words for the GRE flash card set (available for purchase on our website, on Amazon.com, and at major bookstores). However, the flash cards contain *much* more information about each word, including synonyms, etymologies, and idiomatic usages. If you already have the flash cards, we suggest using those as your primary study tool, and using this list as an alphabetic reference.

WORD	P.O.S	DEFINITION	USAGE
abate	(verb)	Reduce, diminish	Her stress over spending so much money on a house abated when the real estate broker told her about the property's 15-year tax abatement.
abdicate	(verb)	Formally give up the throne (or some other power or responsibility)	King Edward VIII of England famously abdicated the throne in order to marry an American divorcée. / Parents can be charged with neglect for abdicating their responsibilities towards

			their children.
aberrant	(adj)	Abnormal, deviant	The teen's aberrant behavior made his family suspect that he was using drugs. / Losing rather than gaining weight over the holidays is certainly an aberration.
abhor	(verb)	Detest, regard with disgust	"Go out with you?" she replied. "I abhor you! I would rather stab myself with a rusty bread knife than be your girlfriend!"
abjure	(verb)	Give up, renounce; repudiate, recant, or shun (especially formally or under oath)	To become a citizen of the United States, you must abjure loyalty to the nation of your birth. / Since enrolling in that nutrition class, she has abjured sugar and saturated fats.
abrasive	(adj)	Rough, suitable for grinding or polishing (such as sandpaper); causing irritation or annoyance	Could the inside of this mascot costume be any more abrasive? It's rubbing my skin raw! I have some seriously abrasive remarks for whomever designed this thing.
abridge	(verb)	Condense or curtail; shorten by omitting parts throughout while	Our romantic vacation was abridged when the babysitter called to say that the kids were sick

		retaining the main idea	and we should come home. / Audio books are almost always abridged, since few people want to listen to a 200-hour book.
abstain	(verb)	Hold back, refrain (especially from something bad or unhealthy); decline to vote	The church board voted on whether to hold an abstinence rally to encourage young people not to become sexually active; while most members voted in favor, one voted against and two abstained, with one abstainer commenting that, as far as she knew, the church's teens were pretty abstemious already.
acme	(noun)	Summit, peak, highest point	The acme of my vacation was when I finally climbed to the acme of the mountain and enjoyed the gorgeous vista.
activism	(noun)	The practice of pursuing political or other goals through vigorous action, often including protests and demonstrations	Lindsay's parents had a hard time accepting that, after incurring \$100,000 in student loans, their daughter had decided to enter the low-paying field of environmental activism.
adhere	(verb)	Stick (to), such as with glue, or to a	I have a message board that adheres to my

		plan or belief	refrigerator with magnets; on it, I've written some affirmations to help me adhere to my diet plan.
admonish	(verb)	Mildly scold; caution, advise, or remind to do something	She was an exacting boss who castigated an employee for jamming the copier, yet she merely admonished her five-year-old for the same offense.
adverse	(adj)	Opposing, harmful	Pioneer women persevered despite adverse circumstances, even when fording a river—baby in one arm, leading a horse with the other—against an adverse current.
advocate	(verb, noun)	Speak or argue in favor of (verb); a person who pleads for a cause or on behalf of another person (noun)	I cannot possibly vote for a candidate who advocates oil drilling in federally protected nature preserves. / Children often have advocates appointed to represent them in court.
aesthetic	(adj, noun)	Concerning the appreciation of beauty or good taste, pertaining to the science of what is beautiful (adj); a set of principles or tastes	The twins were so different. One possessed a truly baroque aesthetic, preferring golden, gilded decor. The other lived in a world of pure logic, untouched by any

		guiding an artistic practice (noun)	aesthetic sense whatsoever; art did not move him, his house was bare, and he married his wife solely because she was a master of calculus.
affable	(adj)	Warm and friendly, pleasant, approachable	The professional wrestler played at belligerence in the ring, but in real life, he was quite an affable fellow: sociable, easy-going, and always ready to lend a hand.
affectation	(noun)	Fake behavior (such as in speech or dress) adopted to give a certain impression	I'm annoyed whenever Americans move to England and suddenly start speaking with an affected British accent; such affectations, when practiced by celebrities, are only likely to alienate their fans.
aggrandize	(verb)	Make greater; exaggerate	I can't stand when my coworker aggrandizes her role in our group projects. / Stop it with your constant self-aggrandizing—we don't care how many automobiles you own!
aggregate	(verb, adj)	Gather together, amount to (verb); constituting a whole made up of	While some of the company's divisions did better than others, in aggregate, we made a

		constituent parts (adj)	profit. / Concrete is created when crushed rock or glass is aggregated with cement; in aggregate, concrete is stronger than cement alone.
alacrity	(noun)	Cheerful or speedy willingness	Any boss wants an employee to respond with alacrity to his or her requests, handling them promptly and with enthusiasm.
alienate	(verb)	Cause to become unfriendly, hostile, or distant	The talk-show host was trying to help, but only alienated her viewers when she suggested that they cope with a tough economy by checking themselves into a spa.
alleviate	(verb)	Lessen, make easier to endure	The stimulus package has alleviated the pangs of the Great Recession, but times are still tough.
ambiguous	(adj)	Not clear, hard to understand, open to having several meanings or interpretations	The meaning of this ancient text is ambiguous—either we are missing some cultural context, or else the writer actually wanted to be mysterious.
ambivalent	(adj)	Uncertain; unable to decide, or wanting to do two	I've been accepted to two amazing graduate programs, one

		contradictory things at once	inexpensive and close to home, and one in a big, exciting city. I'm ambivalent—I don't know how I'm going to decide. / When I asked you if you thought we'd get married some day, your ambivalence hurt my feelings.
analogous	(adj)	Comparable, corresponding in some particular way (making a good analogy)	In the U.S., whenever opponents of a war want to suggest that the war is unwinnable, they point out all the ways in which the war is analogous to the Vietnam War.
anarchy	(noun)	Absence of law or government; chaos, disorder	Once the dictator was assassinated, the country fell into total anarchy, as none of the opposition groups were strong enough to seize power.
anoint	(verb)	Rub or sprinkle oil on; make sacred, such as by a ceremony that includes applying oil to someone	After Principal Smitters raised test scores over 60% at her school, it was only a matter of time before she was anointed superintendent by a fawning school board.
anomaly	(noun)	Deviation from what is common; inconsistency	While the cosmetics division of this company has many

			female executives, it is an anomaly; in the rest of the company, sadly, only 4% of management positions are filled by women.
antagonize	(verb)	Make hostile or unfriendly	“Josie! Stop antagonizing your little brother! Give him back that firetruck and tell him you're sorry for pulling his hair!”
antipathy	(noun)	Deep dislike, aversion, or repugnance, sometimes without reason	As an environmentalist, Mr. Subramanian had nothing but antipathy for the mining company drilling in and polluting his hometown.
apathy	(noun)	Not caring; absence of feeling; lack of interest or concern	Many parents of teenagers are concerned by their indolent teens’ apathy about the future. Few teens are totally apathetic, however, many get quite excited about video games, flirting, or trips to the mall.
apocryphal	(adj)	Of questionable authenticity; false	I'm sorry, but this putative letter from George Washington that you found at a garage sale is clearly apocryphal—it is riddled with anachronisms (for

			instance, Washington was long dead by the time silent films were invented), and also, Washington most certainly didn't refer to Martha Washington as "baby."
appease	(verb)	Pacify, satisfy, relieve; concede to belligerent demands, sometimes at the expense of principles	My mother is so angry she wasn't the first person we called when the baby was born—I'm hoping to appease her by spending Christmas at her house this year.
appreciable	(adj)	Enough to be perceived, considerable	She ruefully concluded that the "Pot Pie Diet" was a scam and had made no appreciable difference in her appearance—after four weeks, she had lost three-quarters of a pound.
arbitrary	(adj)	Based entirely on one's discretion; capricious, unreasonable, or having no basis	The judge's rulings were truly arbitrary: one defendant got community service for stealing a television, and another got three years for the same crime. / It doesn't really matter which brand of baking soda you buy, just arbitrarily pick one so we can get out of this

			grocery store before dinnertime.
arcane	(adj)	Known or understood by only a few; obscure, secret	To win at <i>Jeopardy</i> , you must be full of arcane knowledge. / The wizard's shop was full of arcana, from Latin-to-Ancient Greek dictionaries to entire books on magic spells relating only to elephants.
archaic	(adj)	Characteristic of an earlier period, ancient, primitive	The school's archaic computer system predated even floppy disks—it stored records on tape drives! / Sometimes, when you look up a word in the dictionary, certain definitions are marked “archaic”—unless you are a Shakespeare scholar, you can safely ignore those archaisms.
arduous	(adj)	Very difficult, strenuous; severe, hard to endure	The arduous hike up rocky terrain was all worth it once the hikers reached the summit. / It was an arduous winter on the prairie; the family barely survived.
articulate	(adj, verb)	Using language in a clear, fluent way (adj); speak distinctly or give	She's so articulate that I'm sure she'll make a good lawyer. / The group voted on who

		clarity to an idea (verb)	would be the best spokesperson, able to articulate their needs to the panel.
artifact	(noun)	Any object made by humans, especially those from an earlier time, such as those excavated by archaeologists	The archaeologists dug up countless artifacts, from simple pottery shards and coins to complex written tablets. / The girl's room was full of the artifacts of modern teenage life: Justin Bieber posters, <i>Twilight</i> books, and a laptop open to Facebook.
artless	(adj)	Free of deceit or craftiness, natural, genuine; lacking skill or knowledge, crude, uncultured	Children can be so artless that, when you try to explain war to them, they say things like, "But isn't that mean?" / His artless attempt at negotiating a raise began with "I need more money, please" and ended with "Okay, sorry I asked."
ascertain	(verb)	Find out with certainty	Hopefully, the investigation will allow us to ascertain who is at fault here.
ascetic	(adj, noun)	abstinent or austere in lifestyle (adj); a person who leads an	Ascetics such as monks actually take vows of poverty. / The graduate student lived an ascetic

		austere and simple life without material pleasures, esp. someone who does this for religious reasons (noun)	existence, her apartment containing only a futon couch and a single bowl and set of chopsticks, which she used to eat ramen noodles every night.
assuage	(verb)	Make milder, relieve; soothe, pacify, or calm	After losing a million-dollar account, he tried to assuage his furious boss by pointing out that he was close to winning a new account worth at least as much.
audacious	(adj)	Very bold or brave, often in a rude or reckless way; extremely original	He audaciously asked for a raise after working at the company for less than two months!
augment	(verb)	Make larger	If you memorize the definitions on all of these flash cards, you will have notably augmented your vocabulary!
austere	(adj)	Severe in manner or appearance; very self-disciplined, ascetic; without luxury or ease; sober or serious	Her design sense was so minimalist as to be austere; all-white walls, hard, wooden furniture, not a single picture, throw pillow, or cozy comfort anywhere. / The graduation speaker delivered an austere message: the economy is bad, and academic

			success alone isn't enough to succeed in the job market.
autonomous	(adj)	Self-governing, independent	As leader of an autonomous region, the newly elected president was received as a peer by some world leaders, although he was not entitled to send a representative to the United Nations. / It is normal for young people to desire greater autonomy as they grow up.
aver	(verb)	Declare or affirm with confidence, say	“Despite your insistence that ethics are completely situational,” said the philosophy professor, “I aver that the existence of natural rights inevitably leads to certain immutable ethical boundaries.”
avid	(adj)	Enthusiastic, dedicated, passionate; excessively desirous	An avid cyclist, she was on her bike every weekend, and even bought the same bike that Lance Armstrong last used in the Tour de France. / Avid of power, the young Senator compromised every principle to gain the support—and money—

			of large corporations.
balk	(verb)	Refuse to proceed or to do something	At the company retreat, he reluctantly agreed to participate in the ropes course, but balked at walking over hot coals as a “trust exercise.”
base	(adj)	Morally low, mean, dishonorable; of little or no value; crude and unrefined; counterfeit	His philanthropy was underlied by truly base motives—he not only craved the fawning publicity his donations brought, but he was actually funneling drug money through the Children's Defense Fund! / The supposed “gold bricks” were really base metals covered in a very thin layer of real gold.
belie	(verb)	Contradict or misrepresent	The actress's public persona as a perky “girl next door” belied her private penchant for abusing her assistants and demanding that her trailer be filled with ridiculous luxury goods. / The data belie the accepted theory—either we've made a mistake or we have an amazing new discovery on our hands!

benign	(adj)	Harmless; favorable; kindly, gentle, or beneficial; not cancerous	He was relieved when the biopsy results came back, informing him that the growth was benign. / He's a benign fellow. I'm sure having him assigned to your team at work will be perfectly pleasant.
bogus	(adj)	Fake, fraudulent	The back of this bodybuilding magazine is full of ads for bogus products—this one promises 22-inch biceps just from wearing magnetic armbands!
bolster	(verb)	Strengthen or support	The general requested reinforcements to bolster the defensive line set up at the border. / Some people believe that self-affirmation exercises are an effective way to bolster self-esteem and even performance.
boor	(noun)	Rude, ill-mannered, or insensitive person; a peasant or country bumpkin	Milton was such a boor that, when Jane brought him home to meet her parents, he laughed at their garden gnome and made fun of everyone's hairstyles in old family photos. “Don't be so boorish!” said his mortified girlfriend.

buffer	(noun)	Something that shields, protects, absorbs shock, or cushions	During the colonial era, England wanted Georgia as a buffer between its original colonies and Spanish Florida. / A railroad car has a buffer (similar to a bumper on a car) to absorb shock in case of contact with other cars. / When Joel came out to his family, he used his mother as a buffer. He knew she would be supportive, so he allowed her to relay the news to everyone else, and to relay their responses back to him.
bureaucracy	(noun)	Government characterized by many bureaus and petty administrators or by excessive, seemingly meaningless requirements	Some nations have a worse reputation for bureaucracy than others; in order to get a visa, he had to file papers with four different agencies, wait for hours in three different waiting rooms, and, weeks later, follow up with some petty bureaucrat who complained that the original application should've been filed in triplicate.
burgeon	(verb)	Grow or flourish rapidly; put forth buds or shoots (of	The dictator was concerned about the people's burgeoning

		a plant)	discontent and redoubled his personal security. / Spending an hour a day on vocabulary studies will soon cause your lexicon to burgeon.
buttress	(verb, noun)	Support or encourage (verb); a support or prop, esp. projecting from and supporting the wall of a building (noun)	A self-defense class really helped to buttress Elaine's confidence. / David used his Ph.D. as a buttress against criticism. "I have a doctorate," he would say. "I just don't think you can understand."
bygone	(adj, noun)	Past, former (adj); that which is in the past (usually plural noun)	At the nursing home, the time to reminisce about bygone days was pretty much all the time. / It's tempting to spend our whole high school reunion talking about bygones, but instead, let's toast to the future!
cacophony	(noun)	Harsh, discordant, or meaningless mixture of sounds	The first day of elementary school marching band practice was nothing but cacophony, as students who hadn't learned to play their instruments at all nevertheless banged on or puffed air into them.
candid	(adj)	Open, sincere,	Allow me to be candid:

		honest	you do look rather portly in those pants, and I think you should wear something else. / You have been really secretive about where you've been going after work; we could use a little more candor in this relationship.
canonical	(adj)	Authorized, recognized; pertaining to the canon, or body of accepted rules, standards, or artistic works	School boards often start controversies when replacing canonical books in the curriculum with modern literature; while many people think students should read works more relevant to their lives, others point out that <i>Moby Dick</i> is part of the canon for a reason.
capricious	(adj)	Acting on impulse, erratic	The headmaster's punishments were capricious—break the rules one day, you get a warning; break them another day, you get expelled. / Who needs a plan? A date is more fun with a little caprice—let's just start driving and see what we find!
cartography	(noun)	Mapmaking	The invention of better navigation tools had major effects on

			cartography—the more ships knew precisely where they were sailing, the better the world could be mapped.
castigate	(verb)	Criticize severely; punish in order to correct	At the grocery store, the mother attracted stares when she castigated—rather than merely admonished—her child for throwing a box of instant oatmeal.
catalyst	(noun)	Causer of change	The young manager was a catalyst at the stodgy old company—once he introduced employee laptops, telecommuting, and mobile workstations, even the most conventional of employees totally changed the way they worked.
caustic	(adj)	Capable of corroding metal or burning the skin; very critical or sarcastic	Wait, those chemicals are caustic! You need safety gloves and goggles before performing this experiment, or else you risk not only getting your skin burned off, but also some seriously caustic remarks from our chemistry teacher.
censure	(noun, verb)	Strong disapproval or	The senator was censured by the Senate

		official reprimand (noun); to issue such disapproval or reprimand (verb)	for campaign fund improprieties; in fact, he narrowly avoided being expelled from office.
chauvinism	(noun)	Fanatical patriotism or blind enthusiasm for military glory; undue or biased devotion to any group, cause, etc.	He's such a chauvinist that he denies that any other nation could be better than ours at anything—he insists our wine is better than France's, our ski slopes are better than Norway's, and even that we grow more rice than China!
chronological	(adj)	Arranged in or relating to time order	Joey, I'm afraid you've done the assignment wrong—the point of making a timeline is to put the information in chronological order. You've put it in alphabetical order instead!
clamor	(verb)	Noisy uproar or protest, as from a crowd; a loud, continuous noise	As soon as a scent of scandal emerged, the press was clamoring for details. / The mayor couldn't even make herself heard over the clamor of the protestors.
clinch	(verb)	Make final or settle conclusively; to fasten or hold	When their best player was benched, the team fell behind, but once he was allowed back in the

		together	game, the team was able to clinch the win. / These two pieces have been clinched together with a clamp while the glue dries.
coalesce	(verb)	Come together, unite; fuse together	While at first everyone on the team was jockeying for power and recognition, eventually, the group coalesced and everyone was happy to share credit for a job well-done. / East and West Germany coalesced into a single country in 1990.
cogent	(adj)	Very convincing, logical	Studying logic is an excellent way to improve at formulating cogent arguments. / Nurses who work in the Alzheimer's ward must develop skills for communicating with people who are often not cogent.
commensurate	(adj)	The same in size, extent, etc., equivalent; proportional	According to the course catalog, you may take Advanced Japanese following Japanese III or with commensurate experience with the language.
complacent	(adj)	Self-satisfied, smug; overly	The coach gave a pep talk: "I know we've

		content (and therefore lazy, neglectful, or some other bad quality)	never won a championship before, but we do have an advantage over the six-time state champions we're about to play—they have grown complacent with their success, and now they just assume they'll win without having to sweat.”
complementary	(adj)	Completing; fitting together well; filling mutual needs	“That scarf really complements your outfit,” said Elle. “Thanks for the compliment,” said Danica. / The couple had complementary personalities—when Omar got overwhelmed with the details, Lee took care of everything, and when Lee got too introspective, Omar cheered him up with an insatiable zest for life.
compliant	(adj)	Obeying, submissive; following the requirements	Those who are not compliant with the regulations will be put on probation and possibly expelled. / A compliant child, he never gave his parents any trouble.
concede	(verb)	Give in, admit,	The negotiations were

		yield; acknowledge reluctantly; grant or give up (such as giving up land after losing a war)	pointless, with each side's representatives instructed by their home countries to make no concessions whatsoever. / Quebec was a French concession to Britain in the Treaty of Paris in 1763. / I suppose I will have to concede the argument now that you've looked up evidence on Wikipedia.
conciliatory	(adj)	Reconciling, appeasing, attempting to make the peace	The hotel manager was horrified at how the guest had been treated, and approached him in a conciliatory manner, offering him numerous freebies and apologizing repeatedly.
concur	(verb)	Approve, agree	John Locke wrote that justice is based on the social contract, and I concur—in fact, my latest book is all about contractual justice.
condone	(verb)	Overlook, tolerate, regard as harmless	While underage drinking is illegal, at many universities, it is tacitly condoned by administrations that neglect to enforce antidrinkng policies.
confer	(verb)	Consult, compare views; bestow or	A Ph.D. confers upon a person the right to be

		give	addressed as “Doctor” as well as eligibility to pursue a tenure-track professorship. / Excuse me for a moment to make a call—I can't buy this car until I confer with my spouse.
connoisseur	(noun)	Expert, especially in the fine arts; person of educated, refined tastes	A chocolate connoisseur, Mom eschews grocery store brands and will only eat 80% cocoa-or-higher artisanal chocolate that is less than a week old.
console	(verb, noun)	Lessen the suffering or grief of (verb); a control panel, or small table or cabinet (noun)	I was unable to console Tina after she fell asleep at the console of her airplane and thereby failed her pilot's exam.
consolidate	(verb)	Unite, combine, solidify, make coherent	She consolidated her student loans so she would only have to make one payment per month. / As group leader, Muriel will consolidate all of our research into a single report.
constrict	(verb)	Squeeze, compress; restrict the freedom of	The children strongly disliked being gussied up in constrictive clothing for a formal wedding. / Tourism is now allowed in North

			Korea, but tourists must stay with official tour groups, and their movements are heavily constricted.
construe	(verb)	Interpret or translate	I don't know how you construed my comment as an insult. All I said was, "Wow, I never knew you could sing."
contentious	(adj)	Controversial; prone to causing arguments, especially gratuitous or petty ones	The death penalty is a contentious issue. / My uncle is so contentious that every attempt I made to introduce an uncontroversial topic met with failure; he ranted and raved about the weather, trees, math, and my daughter's enjoyment of oatmeal.
contextualize	(verb)	Place in context, such as by giving the background or circumstances	Virginia Woolf's feminism is hard to truly understand unless contextualized within the mores of the highly restrained, upper-class English society of her time.
conundrum	(noun)	A riddle; any mystery	Sherlock Holmes is famous for his ability to solve the most complex conundrums with simple observation. / The new mystery novel presents an interesting spin on

			the classic locked-room conundrum—how did the perpetrator get in and out of the White House without being detected?
converge	(verb)	Move towards one another or towards a point; unite	I know we're driving to the wedding from different states, but our routes ought to converge when each of us hits I-95—maybe we could converge at a Cracker Barrel for lunch!
conversant	(adj)	Knowledgeable about or experienced with	For an opera singer, she is unusually conversant in physics—she just explained the purpose of the Large Hadron Collider.
conversely	(adverb)	In an opposite way; on the other hand	I am not here to argue that lack of education causes poverty. Conversely, I am here to argue that poverty causes lack of education.
convoluted	(adj)	Twisted; very complicated	Your argument is so convoluted that I'm not even able to understand it enough to start critiquing it. / To get from the hotel room to the pool requires

			following a convoluted path up two staircases and down two others—to get to someplace on the same floor we started on!
copious	(adj)	Plentiful, bountiful	Although she took copious notes in class, she found that she was missing a big picture that would have tied all the information together. / The fertile, copious land yielded a rich harvest.
corroborate	(verb)	Support, add evidence to	You're telling me you were 30 miles away riding a roller coaster when the school was vandalized? I have a hard time believing that. Is there anyone who can corroborate your story?
cosmopolitan	(adj)	Belonging to the entire world, at home globally; free from local or national prejudices or attachments	Trapped in a small town, he dreamed of a more cosmopolitan existence filled with world travel, exotic cuisine, and scintillating parties where he would meet famous authors and other cosmopolites.
countenance	(noun, verb)	Facial expression or face (noun); approve or tolerate (verb)	Her countenance said it all—the look on her face was pure terror. / I saw you cheating off my

			paper, and I can't countenance cheating—either you turn yourself in or I'll report you.
counterintuitive	(adj)	Against what one would intuitively expect	Although it seems counterintuitive, for some extreme dieters, eating more can actually help them to lose weight, since the body is reassured that it is not facing a period of prolonged starvation.
counterpoint	(noun)	Contrasting item, opposite; a complement; the use of contrast or interplay in a work of art	The play's lighthearted, witty narrator provides a welcome counterpoint to the seriousness and grief expressed by the other characters. / The hot peppers work in counterpoint to an otherwise sweet dish.
counterproductive	(adj)	Defeating the purpose; preventing the intended goal	The candidate's attempt to win swing votes in Ohio was actually counterproductive—following his speech in Toledo, his poll numbers actually went down 5%.
covert	(adj)	Secret, veiled, undercover	The soldier trained to be part of covert operations, moving silently and remaining out of the enemy's sight.
crafty	(adj)	Cunning, skillful	A crafty play in

		in deception or underhanded schemes	basketball is the “head-fake”—moving the head in one direction slightly prior to running in the other direction, to try to get a tiny head start on a disoriented pursuer.
craven	(adj)	Very cowardly, lacking courage	The nervous soldier feared he would turn craven in his first firefight, but he actually acted quite bravely.
credibility	(noun)	Believability, trustworthiness	Many famous “experts” with “Dr.” before their names are not medical doctors at all. Any television “doctor” who turns out to have a Ph.D. in botany, for instance, ought to suffer a serious drop in credibility.
credulous	(adj)	Gullible; prone to believing or trusting too easily or without enough evidence	“Did you know you can wash your ears by turning your head on its side in the shower and letting the water run straight through your head?” said the father to his five-year-old daughter. “I’ll try that!” said the credulous little girl.
crescendo	(noun; verb)	Steady increase in force, intensity, or the loudness of a	Mrs. Higgins did love the symphony, but she was also coming down

		musical passage; a climactic moment or peak (noun); to rise in volume or intensity (verb)	with a migraine—by the time the music reached its towering crescendo, her head was pounding. / The administration tried to ignore the protest, but finally had to address the issue when the demonstration reached a crescendo.
culminate	(verb)	Reach the highest point or final stage	A Ph.D. program generally culminates in a written dissertation and its defense to a committee.
cynical	(adj)	Thinking the worst of others' motivations; bitterly pessimistic	Shilpa was so cynical that even when her friends threw her a surprise party, she figured that they only did it so they wouldn't feel so guilty about all the mean things they must be saying behind her back.
daunt	(verb)	Discourage, dishearten, lessen the courage of	Amazingly undaunted after his accident, Devon vowed to complete a marathon in his wheelchair. Not even a dented rim on mile 19 could daunt him—he dauntlessly completed the race anyway.
debase	(verb)	Degrade; lower in	You have debased

		quality, value, rank, etc.; lower in moral quality	yourself by accepting bribes. / Members of the mainstream church argued that the fringe sect was practicing a debased version of the religion, twisting around its precepts and missing the point. / I can tell from the weight that this isn't pure gold, but rather some debased mixed metal.
debunk	(verb)	Expose, ridicule, or disprove false or exaggerated claims	Galileo spent his last years under house arrest for debunking the widely held idea that the Sun revolved around the Earth. / The show <i>MythBusters</i> debunks pseudoscientific claims.
decorous	(adj)	Behaving with propriety and good taste; polite	Miss Etiquette writes an advice column about decorum. One writer asked, "What's the most decorous way to tell guests exactly what I want for my wedding?" Miss Etiquette replied, "Young lady, there is no decorous way to solicit gifts, and even asking that question is entirely indecorous of you."
deem	(verb)	Judge; consider	"You can take the black belt exam when I deem

			you ready, and not a moment before,” said the karate instructor.
deface	(verb)	Vandalize, mar the appearance of	Ernest was charged with three counts of vandalism after being caught defacing a row of townhouses with spray paint.
defamatory	(adj)	Slandorous, injurious to someone's reputation	One interesting issue in free speech law is defamation. / The political blogs are filled with defamatory language; it seems anyone with a computer and an opinion can destroy a politician's reputation these days.
default	(noun, verb)	Failure to act, neglect (noun); fail to fulfill an obligation, especially a financial one (verb)	The government is cracking down on for-profit colleges where a large percentage of the graduates cannot use their degrees to gain employment and end up defaulting on their student loans. / You must elect a new health plan by December 31st or by default you will be re-enrolled in the plan you selected last year.
deference	(noun)	Respectful submission; yielding to the	In many cultures, young people are expected to show deference to older

		authority or opinion of another	people at all times. / I'm not an expert in databases—I'll defer to our programmers on that decision. / Ingrid deferred her college admissions for a year so she could travel the world.
deflect	(verb)	Cause to curve; turn aside, esp. from a straight course; avoid	The purpose of a shield is to deflect arrows or bullets from an enemy. / Every time he was asked a difficult question, Senator Warrington deflected by changing the topic, saying he'd answer later, or even—insincerely, it seemed—calling for a moment of prayer.
deleterious	(adj)	Harmful, unhealthful	The Resident Assistant told the first-year students, “I think you will find not only that drugs are illegal and will result in expulsion, but also that drug abuse will have a deleterious effect on anyone's grades.”
delineate	(verb)	Mark the outline of; sketch; describe in detail	I do need the cash, but I'm not signing up for this psychological experiment unless you delineate what's going

			to happen.
denigrate	(verb)	Belittle, attack the reputation of	Many jokes in the <i>Meet the Parents</i> trilogy come from Robert De Niro's character denigrating Ben Stiller's character for being a male nurse.
denote	(verb)	Stand as a name or symbol for; indicate (This word contrasts with “connote,” which describes what something implies or suggests beyond its literal meaning.)	The company's brand denotes quality; the marketing team has done a fantastic job of associating the company's image with fine service. / There's nothing in the denotation of “crotchety” [grumpy, having strong and irrational preferences] that indicates any particular group of people, but due to the expression “crotchety old man,” the word connotes, for many people, an image of an especially unpleasant male senior citizen.
deride	(verb)	Mock, scoff at, laugh at contemptuously	The manager really thought that deriding his employees as “stupid” or “lazy” would motivate them to work harder; instead, it motivated them to

			constantly hide his office supplies as an act of revenge.
derivative	(adj)	Derived from something else; not original	The singer's first album was a disappointment, derivative of several hit albums from the previous year, as though a management team had simply picked out the elements from other popular songs that they thought would make the most money.
desiccate	(verb)	Thoroughly dried up, dehydrated	The key to maintaining odor-free shoes is to desiccate the insole by placing a drying agent, such as a small pouch of baking soda, inside the shoe between wears. / Beef jerky is a desiccated meat product.
detached	(adj)	Impartial, disinterested; unconcerned, distant, aloof	He found her detached demeanor inappropriate for a funeral. It's fine to politely ask how someone died, but it's not appropriate to coldly question a relative on the medical history of the deceased. / The divorce proceeding was full of anger and recriminations, but the

			judge was able to make a detached decision.
deterrent	(noun)	Something that restrains or discourages	Some argue that the death penalty is a deterrent to crime; that is, the point is not just to punish the guilty, but to frighten other prospective criminals.
diatribe	(noun)	Bitter, abusive attack or criticism; rant	I'd stay out of the living room for a while—Grandpa's on another one of his diatribes about how it's un-American to call a large coffee a “venti.” You can hear him ranting from here!
didactic	(adj)	Intended to instruct; teaching, or teaching a moral lesson	She might have been Teacher of the Year at work, but at home, her husband wished she would turn off her didactic personality. “Honey,” he said, “I really don't need you to use everything as a learning opportunity.” / The child was disappointed when the storybook turned didactic in the end, with the teddy bears—and the reader—being admonished never to lie.

digress	(verb)	Go off-topic when speaking or writing	Grandpa digressed quite a bit while you were in the kitchen—he was telling us an old war story, but somehow now he's ranting about how nobody celebrates Arbor Day anymore. That digression could take awhile.
din	(noun)	Loud, confused noise, esp. for a long period of time	This hotel was described as “near all the hot spots,” but I didn't realize that I wouldn't be able to sleep due to the all-night din from partygoers.
disabuse	(verb)	Free someone from a mistake in thinking	Do you really believe that toilets flush one way in the Northern hemisphere and another way in the Southern? Any physicist would be happy to disabuse you of that silly notion.
discerning	(adj)	Having good judgment or insight; able to distinguish mentally	In an age in which we are bombarded with advertising, it's important to be a discerning consumer. For instance, the term “all natural” is not federally regulated and doesn't have to mean anything at all, so a smart shopper still reads

			ingredients.
discredit	(adj)	Injure the reputation of, destroy credibility of or confidence in	Congresswoman Huffman's opponent tried to use her friendship with a certain radical extremist to discredit her, even though the congresswoman hadn't seen this so-called extremist since sixth grade summer camp.
discrepancy	(noun)	Difference or inconsistency	When there is a discrepancy between a store's receipts and the amount of money in the register, the cashier is suspected of pocketing the difference.
discriminating	(adj)	Judicious, discerning, having good judgment or insight (as an adj, positive spin; as a verb, negative spin!)	He is a man of discriminating tastes—all his suits are handmade in Italy, and I once saw him send back an entrée when he complained that black truffle oil had been substituted for white. The chef was astounded. / You can tell a real Prada bag by the discriminating mark on the inside.
disingenuous	(adj)	Insincere, not genuine	Steven's offer of help turned out to be disingenuous; when it

			was finally time for me to move, he was nowhere to be found! / My dog's wide-eyed expression of remorse for playing with the children's toys must be disingenuous, because she continues to snatch a toy every chance she gets.
disinterested	(adj)	Unbiased, impartial; not interested	Let's settle this argument once and for all! We'll get a disinterested observer to judge who can sing the highest note.
disjointed	(adj)	Disconnected, not coherent, jerky	The novel seemed disjointed, as though whole chunks of it were missing, or as though the author had tried to stitch together drafts of several different stories.
dismiss	(verb)	Allow to disperse or leave; fire from a job; put aside or reject, especially after only a brief consideration	"Before I dismiss class," said the teacher, "I want to remind you of the importance of dismissing biases in your research by ruling out or adjusting for factors other than the variable you are testing that may have led to your results."
dispassionate	(adj)	Unbiased, not	The defendant tearfully

		having a selfish or personal motivation; calm, lacking emotion	described how much her young child needed her at home, but the judge, who dispassionately sentenced her to 10 years for selling drugs, was unmoved.
dispatch	(noun, verb)	Speed, promptness; send off or deal with in a speedy way	So, you want to be a bike messenger? I need messengers who approach every delivery with alacrity, care, and dispatch—if the customers wanted their packages to arrive slowly, they'd use the post office. / Acting with all possible dispatch, emergency services dispatched a rescue squad to the scene.
disperse	(verb)	Scatter, spread widely, cause to vanish	Because the demonstrators didn't have a permit, the police showed up with megaphones, demanding loudly that the crowd disperse. / Get the hose so I can disperse the dirt on our driveway.
disposition	(noun)	A person's general or natural mood; tendency	She was possessed of a kind and helpful disposition—she wouldn't just help you

			move, she'd bring home-baked muffins to the affair. / I could really use some help in the kitchen, if you are so disposed.
disquieting	(adj)	Disturbing, causing anxiety	Mr. Ramirez's lack of emotion at his wife's death was disquieting—so much so, in fact, that even his own family began to suspect he'd had something to do with it. / He was deeply disquieted by the racism he encountered in his new neighborhood.
disseminate	(verb)	Scatter, spread about, broadcast	Many plants use attractive fruits to disseminate their seeds—animals eat the fruit and excrete the seeds, allowing new plants to grow. / In the 1760s, revolutionary ideas were disseminated via pamphlets such as Thomas Paine's "Common Sense."
dissent	(verb, noun)	Disagree or take an opposing view, esp. in relation to a formal body such as a government,	Judge Antonin Scalia cast the only dissenting vote, explaining in his written decision why he thought all the other justices had it wrong. /

		political party, or church; such a view	Not every country has a right to free speech (and thus to dissent), although nations that throw dissenters in jail are condemned by the international community.
dissonance	(noun)	Harsh, inharmonious sound; cacophony; disagreement	After allowing her sixth-grader's "heavy metal" band to practice in her living room, Mrs. Rosen decided she'd better get used to dissonance.
distill	(verb)	Purify; extract the essential elements of	While traveling in certain countries, it is important to only drink distilled water so you don't get sick. / Jules, it's not necessary to read your entire PowerPoint presentation to us. Can you just distill it down to the main point?
diverge	(verb)	Differ, deviate; branch off or turn aside, as from a path	Go five miles until the old post office, then the road diverges—you want the branch that winds off to the left. / The high school sweethearts found that their paths diverged when they were accepted to different colleges.

divest	(verb)	Deprive or strip of a rank, title, etc., or of clothing or gear; to sell off holdings (opposite of invest)	When she found out that the most profitable stock in her portfolio was that of a company that tested products on animals, she immediately divested by telling her broker to sell the stock. / Once his deception was exposed, he was divested of his position on the Board.
divine	(verb)	Discover through divination or supernatural means; perceive by insight	I've been poring over these quarterly reports all day, trying to divine whether I should buy or sell this stock.
document	(verb)	Support with evidence, cite sources in a detailed way, create documentary evidence of	Journalists embedded with military units are able to document a war as it happens. / It's hard to deny her conclusion when her book is so well documented—she cites a relevant scientific study on practically every page.
dogma	(noun)	A system of principles laid down by an authority; established belief	It is part of the dogma of modern education that there are multiple intelligences that are equally valuable; try to suggest that some people just aren't that smart, and you'll find yourself a pariah. /

			Dogmatic people will never change their minds, even in the face of evidence.
dormant	(adj)	Asleep, inactive, on a break	Some famous writers' skills have lain dormant until quite late in life; Laura Ingalls Wilder didn't publish <i>Little House on the Prairie</i> until she was 65.
dubious	(adj)	Doubtful, questionable, suspect	This applicant's résumé is filled with dubious qualifications—somehow I doubt he both invented peanut butter and was a member of the first moon mission.
e.g.	(abbreviation for Latin “exempli gratia”)	For example, such as	He was positively traumatized by the romantic comedies his girlfriend made him watch (e.g., <i>He's Just Not That into You</i>).
eccentric	(adj)	Peculiar, odd, deviating from the norm, esp. in a whimsical way	The old woman was eccentric but harmless—not many senior citizens wear a train conductor's uniform and carry a boom box. / The eccentricity of a planet's orbit is the amount by which it deviates from a perfect circle; in general, comets are far

			more eccentric than known planets.
eclectic	(adj)	Selecting the best of everything or from many diverse sources	Eclectic taste is helpful in being a DJ—crowds love to hear the latest hip-hop mixed with ‘80s classics and other unexpected genres of music. / The restaurant features an eclectic menu—if you don't like artisanal pasta or steak frites, try the chow mein!
eclipse	(noun, verb)	The obscuring of one thing by another, such as the sun by the moon or a person by a more famous or talented person (noun); to obscure, darken, make less important (verb)	During a solar eclipse, the moon eclipses the Sun. / Billy Ray Cyrus, who had a hit song, “Achy Breaky Heart,” in the ‘90s, has long since found his fame eclipsed by that of his daughter, Miley.
efficacy	(noun)	The quality of being able to produce the intended effect	Extensive trials will be necessary to determine whether the drug's efficacy outweighs the side effects. / I am having trouble cutting my steak with this butter knife; I'm going to ask the waiter for a more efficacious implement.
egalitarian	(adj)	Related to belief	After moving to a more

		in the equality of all people, esp. in political, economic, or social spheres	liberal part of the country, the couple was pleased to have neighbors who shared their views of egalitarian marriage—for instance, men and women could be found in equal proportions downshifting to part-time work to make time for child-care.
egregious	(adj)	Extraordinarily or conspicuously bad; glaring	Your conduct is an egregious violation of our Honor Code—not only did you steal your roommate's paper off his computer and turn it in as your own, you also sold his work to a plagiarism website so other cheaters could purchase it!
elated	(adj)	Very happy, in high spirits	I am elated that you flew my twin brother in from Australia to surprise me at my birthday party!
elevate	(verb)	Raise, lift up; lift the spirits of; move up to a higher rank or status or raise up to a higher spiritual or	After a year getting coffee and making copies, he hoped to be promoted to a more elevated position suitable for a law school graduate. / Our goal

		intellectual plane	here at Morality Publishing is not just to sell books, but to elevate our readers social consciences.
elicit	(verb)	Call forth, bring out, evoke	The touchdown elicited wild cheers from the crowd. / While the death of Ellen's elderly cat was indeed sad, Ellen's constant, mournful looks whenever anyone mentioned any animal at all were nothing but a play to elicit sympathy.
eloquent	(adj)	Marked by forceful, fluid, apt speech; expressive, emotionally moving	Wow, he's such an eloquent speaker, he could sell snow to Antarticans! / When Mom suggested that everyone might enjoy a museum instead of the beach, she was met with the children's eloquent looks of disgust.
embellish	(verb)	Decorate, add ornamentation; enhance (a story) with fictional or fanciful details	Every time she tells that story, she embellishes it quite a bit—at first, she was lost in the woods, and then she was found. The part with the grizzly bear was added later. / The Christmas sweater was embellished with festive jingle bells!

eminent	(adj)	Prominent, distinguished, of high rank	The undergraduate shocked everyone by asking the eminent old professor, “Really? What makes you such an expert?” / “Your Eminence,” said the bishop to the Pope, “Don't forget this copy of your speech!”
empirical	(adj)	Coming from, based on, or able to be verified by experience or experimentation; not purely based on theory	The Ancient Greeks philosophized about the nature of matter (concluding, for instance, that everything was made of earth, water, air, and fire) without any empirical evidence; that is, the very idea of conducting experiments hadn't been invented yet. / People always knew empirically that when something is dropped, it falls to the ground; the theory of gravity later explained why.
emulate	(verb)	Copy in an attempt to equal or be better than	The ardent <i>Star Trek</i> fan emulated Captain Kirk in every way possible—right down to the uniform.
enervate	(verb)	Tire out; weaken (this definition can function both	After taking the SAT in the morning and playing in a soccer game in the

		with and without an object)	afternoon, Trina was truly enervated before the prom even began. “You dance like a grandmother with osteoporosis,” said her date.
enhance	(verb)	Raise to a higher value, desirability, etc.	The cosmetics industry stays in business because so many people want to enhance their appearances.
enigma	(noun)	Puzzle, mystery, riddle; mysterious or contradictory person	The enormous rock sculptures in Stonehenge are truly an enigma—were they created as part of a religious observance, or in deference to a great ruler? We may never know.
entitlement	(noun)	Having the right to certain privileges; believing, sometimes without cause, that one deserves or has a right to certain privileges	Many bosses complain about young people's sense of entitlement—raised on a steady diet of praise from parents and teachers, these young people are shocked to be expected to “pay their dues” at a new job.
enumerate	(verb)	Count or list; specify one-by-one	The Bill of Rights enumerates the basic rights held by every citizen of the United States. / I don't have

			time to enumerate all the steps involved in baking a cake—just find a recipe on the internet!
ephemeral	(adj)	Lasting only a short time, fleeting	“Thank you for this jacket that says ‘Eugene's Girl,’” said Marie, “but I fear that your love will prove to be ephemeral—over the last two years, I've seen four other girls in school with the same jacket. Do you buy them in six-packs?”
equitable	(adj)	Fair, equal, just	As the university president was heavily biased towards the sciences, faculty in the liberal arts felt they had to fight to get an equitable share of funding for their departments.
erratic	(adj)	Inconsistent, wandering, having no fixed course	When someone engages in erratic behavior, family members often suspect drug use or mental illness. However, sometimes the person is just building a top-secret invention in the garage!
erroneous	(adj)	Mistaken, in error; improper, morally incorrect	Hilda was completely unable to assemble her new desk chair after the

			instructions erroneously instructed her to screw the left armrest onto a small lever on the bottom of the seat.
erudite	(adj)	Scholarly, knowledgeable; possessing deep, often systematic, knowledge	Some have said that Americans dislike erudite leaders; while German leaders frequently have Ph.D.'s, even speaking a foreign language is considered pretentious by many American voters.
eschew	(verb)	Shun, avoid, abstain from	As a vegan, he eschewed not only meat and dairy but also anything made of leather.
esoteric	(adj)	Understood by or intended for only a few; secret	In his first year of university-level physics, he felt he was merely memorizing information found in every textbook on the subject; by his fourth year, he spent his days poring over esoteric journal articles that few people had ever read or understood.
estimable	(adj)	Worthy of esteem, admirable; able to be estimated	As the first black president of the <i>Harvard Law Review</i> , Barack Obama presented an estimable

			résumé when he ran for president in 2008. / Riding a roller coaster is safer than driving on the highway, but there is still an estimable risk.
eulogy	(noun)	Speech of praise or written work of praise, esp. a speech given at a funeral	While it was hard for Xing to write a eulogy for his friend, he was pleased to be able to tell others at the funeral some wonderful things about him that they hadn't known. / The review of the book was pure eulogy—usually, this publication runs more balanced articles.
exacerbate	(verb)	Make worse (more violent, severe, etc.), inflame; irritate or embitter (a person)	Allowing your band to practice in our garage has greatly exacerbated my headache.
exacting	(adj)	Very severe in making demands; requiring precise attention	The boxing coach was exacting, analyzing Joey's footwork down to the millimeter and forcing him to repeat movements hundreds of times until they were correct.
exculpate	(verb)	Clear from guilt or blame	The security camera footage showing Mr. Murphy to have been in

			a casino the entire night turned out to be just the evidence needed to exculpate him of robbing a bank 50 miles away.
exhaustive	(adj)	Comprehensive, thorough, exhausting a topic or subject, accounting for all possibilities; draining, tending to exhaust	The <i>Standard Book of British Birds</i> provides an exhaustive treatment of the subject—you will find that not a single British bird has been omitted. / The rebels finally surrendered after an exhaustive siege that left them without ammunition or even food.
explicit	(adj)	Direct, clear, fully revealed; clearly depicting sex or nudity	The goal of my motivational talk is to make explicit the connection between staying in school and avoiding a life of crime.
exponent	(noun)	Person who expounds or explains; champion, advocate, or representative	An exponent of clean fuel, he petitioned the state government to commit to replacing conventional energy with solar and wind energy where possible.
extraneous	(adj)	Irrelevant; foreign, coming from without, not belonging	This essay would be stronger if you removed extraneous information; this paragraph about the author's life doesn't

			happen to be relevant to your thesis. / Maize, which originated in the New World, is extraneous to Europe.
extrapolate	(verb)	Conjecture about an unknown by projecting information about something known; predict by projecting past experience	No, I've never been to Bryn Mawr, but I've visited several small, private women's colleges in the Northeast, so I think I can extrapolate.
facetious	(adj)	Joking, humorous, esp. inappropriately; not serious, concerned with frivolous things	When I said, "Sure, you can take anything in my house as a souvenir of this study session," I was being facetious! I would like my nightgown back now. / He's a facetious person—I doubt he will take your offer of a spiritual quest very seriously.
facilitate	(verb)	Make easier, help the progress of	A good meeting facilitator lets everyone be heard while still keeping the meeting focused. / As a midwife, my goal is simply to facilitate a natural process.
fallacious	(adj)	Containing a fallacy, or mistake in logic; logically	The formal study of logic can enable a student to more easily

		unsound; deceptive	identify fallacious reasoning and, furthermore, to point out its fallacies.
fanatical	(adj)	Excessively devoted, enthusiastic, or zealous in an uncritical way	We avoid our neighbors—they're fanatics who can't go five minutes without trying to convert you to their beliefs. / Mrs. Becker was fanatical about grammar, once deducting 15 points from a student's paper for a misused semicolon—and it was a physics class!
fanciful	(adj)	Whimsical, capricious; imaginary; freely imaginative rather than based on reason or reality	The play was set in a fanciful version of New York City, one where all the cab drivers spoke perfect English and the Statue of Liberty seemed to be in the middle of the island.
fathom	(verb)	Measure the depth of (usually of water) as with a sounding line; penetrate and discover the meaning of, understand	I cannot even remotely fathom how you interpreted an invitation to sleep on my couch as permission to take my car on a six-hour joyride!
feasible	(adj)	Possible; logical or likely; suitable	Your plan to promote our product launch with a parade is just not

			feasible—we don't have the money or enough time to get the permits.
fidelity	(noun)	Faithfulness, loyalty; strict observance of duty; accuracy in reproducing a sound or image	Wedding vows typically include a promise of fidelity—such as “forsaking all others as long as I may live.”
figurative	(adj)	Metaphorical, based on figures of speech; containing many figures of speech (as fancy-sounding writing); related to portraying human or animal figures, as opposed to abstract objects	The painter was renowned for his figurative art, including many portraits—he had been known to say that abstract artists were just people who had never learned to draw. / Highly figurative language can be difficult for English language learners; for instance, to “throw the baby out with the bath water” refers to being too hasty and unwisely getting rid of the good with the bad.
finesse	(noun, verb)	Extreme delicacy, subtlety, or diplomacy in handling a sensitive situation or in a performance or skill (noun); use tact or diplomacy;	After the prince deeply insulted his hosts, the diplomat was able to finesse the situation, playing it off as a translation error and getting the negotiations back on track.

		employ a deceptive strategy (verb)	
flag	(verb)	Get tired, lose enthusiasm; hang limply or droop	Our grandmother is so physically fit that she was ready to make the rounds of the entire amusement park again after lunch, while most of us were flagging and just wanted to sit.
fleeting	(adj)	Passing quickly, transitory	I had assumed our summer romance would be fleeting, so I was very surprised when you proposed marriage!
foment	(verb)	Incite, instigate, stir up, promote the growth of; apply medicated liquid to a body part	The revolutionary group was quietly fomenting a rebellion, galvanizing student radicals, leading unions in revolutionary songs, and anonymously pasting incendiary posters in every quarter of the city.
foreshadow	(verb)	Indicate or suggest beforehand, presage	You didn't know this was a horror movie? I thought it was pretty clear that the children's ghost story around the campfire was meant to foreshadow the horrible things that would happen to them years later as teenagers at a motel in the middle of

			the woods.
forfeit	(verb)	Surrender or lose as a result of an error, crime, or failure to fulfill an obligation	“The rules are clear,” said the umpire. “This is a co-ed league, and if your team doesn't have at least three women, you forfeit. Sorry, everybody, no game today!” / If you are found guilty of defrauding this casino, the forfeiture of your winnings will be only the first of the consequences coming your way.

fortify	(verb)	Strengthen, invigorate, encourage	The white bread found in American grocery stores has been stripped of all the nutrients naturally found in wheat, and then artificially fortified with vitamins and minerals. / The general called for reinforcements to fortify the defenses around the capital.
fringe	(noun, adj)	On the margin, periphery (adj); the people in a group who hold the most extreme views (noun)	In America, reincarnation is a fringe belief, but in primarily Hindu countries, the belief is quite mainstream. / Stacey and Mark liked to say they lived on the fringe of the big city, but really they had just moved to the suburbs.
frugal	(adj)	Economical, thrifty, not wasteful with money; inexpensive	It wasn't terribly surprising when Lea—who was so frugal in restaurants that she always drank water, ate salad, and requested a separate check—said she had never tried lobster.
futile	(adj)	Producing no useful result, ineffective; trivial or unimportant	She spent months trying to coax Fluffy to fetch and sit, but it was futile—cats just can't be trained to perform tricks.
gainsay	(verb)	Declare false, deny; oppose	The professor is quite intolerant of challenges to her opinions—she's been known to lower the grade of any student who dares gainsay her.
garrulous	(adj)	Talkative, wordy,	Uncle Bill is so garrulous that

		rambling	our dinner conversation lasted three hours—and the only person who said more than ten words was Uncle Bill.
gauche	(adj)	Tactless, lacking social grace, awkward, crude	It is terribly gauche to put ketchup on your steak and then talk with your mouth full as you eat it. That's the last time I ever bring you to a nice place.
gawky	(adj)	Physically awkward (esp. of a tall, skinny person, often used to describe teenagers)	As a teenager, she thought of herself as gawky and often slouched so as not to seem so much taller than her peers; of course, now that she's a supermodel, no one thinks of her as gawky at all.
germane	(adj)	Relevant and appropriate, on-topic	This is a business meeting, not a social club—let's keep our comments germane to the issue of the new campaign.
gist	(noun)	Main idea, essence	I didn't read the whole book, but I read enough to get the gist.
glib	(adj)	Fluent and easy in a way that suggests superficiality or insincerity	The used car salesman's description of the car was as glib as Luis expected. “This old girl sure is a distinguished old thing,” he said. “She'll be good to you if you're good to her.” Luis responded, “What the heck does that even mean?”
goosebumps	(noun)	The “bumps” created by hairs	This detective novel is so compelling; I got goosebumps

		standing up on the skin in response to cold, fear, etc.	when Clarice started talking to Hannibal!
gradation	(noun)	A progression, a process taking place gradually, in stages; one of these stages	The hill's gradation was so gradual that even those on crutches were able to enjoy the nature trail. / The novel's language graded from the vernacular to the erudite so gradually that you practically didn't realize until the end that the speaker had become educated almost before your eyes.
gregarious	(adj)	Sociable, pertaining to a flock or crowd	"We need to be a little more productive and a little less gregarious," said the chemistry teacher when he saw that the two-person lab groups had devolved into clusters of five and six students standing around talking and laughing.
guile	(noun)	Clever deceit, cunning, craftiness	The game of poker is all about guile, manipulating your own body language, and patter to lead other players to erroneous conclusions about the cards you're holding.
hackneyed	(adj)	So commonplace as to be stale; not fresh or original	This screenplay is so hackneyed—the leading lady has a quirky, artsy job in the city and has a minor problem early in the movie from which the male lead rescues her, and they get together but then

			break up due to a misunderstanding, and then they end up together anyway, all while the female lead's “sassy” friend gives advice. Ugh. I'll bet they're auditioning Jennifer Aniston right now.
hardy	(adj)	Bold, brave, capable of withstanding hardship, fatigue, cold, etc.	While the entire family enjoyed the trip to South America, only the hardier members even attempted to hike to the top of Ecuador's tallest volcano.
haven	(noun)	Harbor or port; refuge, safe place	The relief workers set up the camp as a haven from persecution.
hearken	(verb)	Listen, pay attention to	“Hearken, students!” said the old-fashioned music teacher. “We are going to practice ‘Hark, the Herald Angels Sing.’
hedonist	(noun)	Person devoted to pleasure	A vacation is a fine time to practice hedonism, letting your troubles go and indulging in every conceivable luxury and pleasure.
heterogeneous	(adj)	Different in type, incongruous; composed of different types of elements	Rather than build the wall with plain brick, we used a heterogeneous mixture of stones—they are not only different colors, but a variety of sizes as well.
hierarchy	(noun)	A ranked series; a	The activist, accustomed to

		classification of people according to rank, ability, etc.; a ruling body	groups ruled by consensus, was quite surprised to find that the Eco-Action Coalition was led by a strict hierarchy: members followed orders from district leaders, district leaders from regional leaders, and regional leaders from the national head.
hodgepodge	(noun)	Mixture of different kinds of things, jumble	The comedian's book wasn't a proper memoir, but more a hodgepodge of old bits, personal stories that went nowhere, random political opinions, and childhood photos.
homogeneous	(adj)	Of the same kind; uniform throughout	While Sweden seems to have solved many of its social ills, critics point out that Sweden's largely homogeneous population doesn't present the challenges that exist in a more diverse nation with many cultures and languages.
hyperbole	(noun)	Deliberate exaggeration for effect	Oh, come on. Saying “That movie was so bad it made me puke” was surely hyperbole. I strongly doubt that you actually vomited during or following <i>The Back-Up Plan</i> .
idiosyncrasy	(noun)	Characteristic or habit peculiar to an individual; peculiar quality, quirk	Sometimes, the richer people get, the more idiosyncratic they become. After he made his first billion, he began traveling with a pet iguana, sleeping in an oxygen

			chamber, and, oddly, speaking with a slight Dutch accent.
illiberality	(noun)	Narrow-mindedness, bigotry; strictness or lack of generosity	Students protested the illiberality of an admissions policy that made no allowances for those from disadvantaged areas or backgrounds who may not have had access to advanced classes and tutors.
imminent	(adj)	Ready to occur, impending	In the face of imminent war, the nation looked to FDR for reassurance. / Everyone was excited and nervous; Madonna's arrival was imminent!
impair	(verb)	Make worse, weaken	Playing in a rock band without earplugs will almost certainly impair your hearing over time.
impartial	(adj)	Unbiased, fair	Judge Gonzales recused himself from the case because, having a personal connection to the school where the shooting took place, he did not think he could be appropriately impartial.
impede	(verb)	Hold back, obstruct the progress of	I didn't realize business school would be entirely group work; sadly, there's always at least one person in every group who impedes the group's progress more than helps it.
implication	(noun)	Act of implying or that which is implied; close	When the boss said, "Times are tight around here, I just think you should know," the

		connection, esp. in an incriminating way	implication was that maybe we should start looking for new jobs. / She implicated her boyfriend in the robbery after less than 20 minutes of interrogation.
implicit	(adj)	Implied, not stated directly; involved in the very essence of something, unquestionable	He didn't have to be told to resign; it was implicit in his not getting the promotion that he had no future at the company. / I enjoy ice climbing with my father because, in such a dangerous situation, it's important to have a partner you trust implicitly.
implode	(verb)	Burst inward; fall apart	The startup struggled for years before it simply imploded—the management team broke into factions, all the clients were scared off, and employees who hadn't been paid in weeks began taking the office computers home with them in retribution.
inadvertent	(adj)	Unintentional; characterized by a lack of attention, careless	In attempting to perfect his science project, he inadvertently blew a fuse and plunged his family's home into darkness.
inasmuch	(adv)	In like manner, considering that (contraction of “in as much,” generally followed by “as”)	Inasmuch as you missed my birthday party to do the Walk for the Cure, I am not angry at all. Good for you for doing that! / Normally, a student would graduate in four years,

			but inasmuch as you failed several courses in your first two semesters, that will now be impossible for you.
incendiary	(adj)	Setting on fire, pertaining to arson; arousing strife, rebellion, etc.; “inflaming” the senses	The college suspended him for creating an incendiary website, encouraging sit-ins and protests, but the ACLU defended his right to freedom of speech. / It is illegal to bring incendiaries on a plane—there are many good reasons why you may not have a stick of dynamite in your carry-on.
incentive	(noun)	Something that encourages greater action or effort, such as a reward	A controversial program in a failing school system uses cash payments as an incentive for students to stay in school.
inchoate	(adj)	Just begun, undeveloped, unorganized	The first few weeks of language class went well, but her inchoate French was all but useless when she found herself at an academic conference in Quebec.
incipient	(adj)	Just beginning; in a very early stage	The movie producer was devastated when, due to legal trouble over the screenplay, the incipient project was crushed before it had even begun shooting.
incongruous	(adj)	Out of place, inappropriate, not harmonious	Among the student artwork posted in the halls, Angelina's submission was incongruous, a dark, gruesome, and even

			worldly work amidst the happy family portraits and other childish drawings.
inconsequential	(adj)	Insignificant, unimportant; illogical	You wrote a bestselling book and got a stellar review in the <i>New York Times</i> —whatever your cousin has to say about it is simply inconsequential.
incorporate	(verb)	Include, take in; combine, unite; form a legal corporation; embody, give physical form to	When a business incorporates, it becomes a separate legal entity; for instance, the business can declare bankruptcy without the owners doing so. / Local legend has it that ghosts can incorporate on one night of the year and walk among the living.
indeterminate	(adj)	Not fixed or determined, indefinite; vague	The results of the drug trial were indeterminate; further trials will be needed to ascertain whether the drug can be released. / The lottery can have an indeterminate number of winners—the prize is simply divided among them.
indifferent	(adj)	Not caring, having no interest; unbiased, impartial	Do whatever you want; I'm indifferent. I won't even notice.
inform	(verb)	Inspire, animate; give substance, essence, or context to; be the characteristic quality of	Her work as an art historian is informed by a background in drama; where others see a static tableau, she sees a protagonist, a conflict, a denouement.

ingenuous	(adj)	Genuine, sincere, not holding back; naïve	Multilevel marketing scams prey on the ingenuous, those who really think there's someone out there who just wants to help them get rich.
ingrained	(adj)	Deep-rooted, forming part of the very essence; worked into the fiber	Religious observance had been ingrained in him since birth; he could not remember a time when he didn't pray five times a day.
inherent	(adj)	Existing as a permanent, essential quality; intrinsic	New research seems to support the idea that humans have an inherent sense of justice—even babies become upset at puppet shows depicting unfairness, and are gratified at seeing the “bad” puppets punished.
innocuous	(adj)	Harmless, inoffensive	While it's quite acrid in here, the fumes that come from our factory are completely innocuous—you don't need a face mask unless you'd like one.
intelligible	(adj)	Able to be understood, clear	You are doing a disservice to all music by listening through those horrible speakers! None of the lyrics are even intelligible! I'll bet you have no idea what this song is even about!
intractable	(adj)	Difficult to control, manage, or manipulate; hard to cure; stubborn	That student is positively intractable! Last week, we talked about the importance of staying in your seat during the

			lesson. This week, she not only got up mid-class, but she actually scrambled on top of a bookcase and refused to come down! / Back injuries often result in intractable pain; despite treatment, patients never feel fully cured.
intrepid	(adj)	Fearless, brave, enduring in the face of adversity	Intrepid explorers Lewis and Clark led the first U.S. expedition to the West Coast, facing bitter winters and rough terrain.
intrinsic	(adj)	Belonging to the essential nature of a thing	Despite all this high-tech safety equipment, skydiving is an intrinsically dangerous proposition. / Communication is intrinsic to a healthy relationship.
jargon	(noun)	Vocabulary specific to a group or occupation; convoluted or unintelligible language	The information my doctor gave me was so full of medical jargon I couldn't understand it at all! I'm going to look on the Internet for something written for regular people.
jocular	(adj)	Joking or given to joking all the time; jolly, playful	If we were friends, I'm sure I'd find his antics amusing, but as his professor, I do wish he'd contribute some serious comments to the class discussion instead of his constant stream of jocular comments.
judicious	(adj)	Using good judgment; wise,	In his will, the old titan of industry left little to his hard-

		sensible	partying younger son, and left the bulk of his estate to the more judicious older son, with instructions that the older son see that the rest of the family was taken care of.
juncture	(noun)	Critical point in time, such as a crisis or a time when a decision is necessary; a place where two things are joined together	We are at a critical juncture in the history of this organization: either we can remain a nonprofit, or we can register as a political action committee and try to expand our influence. / The little canoe started to sink when it split at the juncture between the old wood and the new material used to repair it.
keen	(adj)	Sharp, piercing; very perceptive or mentally sharp; intense (of a feeling)	Dogs have a keen sense of smell. / As homecoming queen, she had experienced the envy of others, but their jealousy only grew more keen when she was selected for a small role in a movie.
kudos	(noun)	Praise, honor, congratulations	"Kudos on your amazing GRE score!" said the teacher. / While the critics weren't impressed, the play received plentiful kudos from the audience.
lackluster	(adj)	Not shiny; dull, mediocre; lacking brilliance or vitality	Many young people today are so accustomed to being praised by parents and adults that they are shocked when a lackluster effort in the

			workplace receives the indifference or mild disapproval it deserves.
laconic	(adj)	Using few words, concise	The boss was famously laconic; after allowing his employees to present their new plan for an entire hour, he finally responded, "Fine."
lament	(verb, noun)	Mourn; express grief, sorrow, or regret (verb); an expression of grief, esp. as a song or poem (noun)	Silda said she couldn't make it to the party—she's still lamenting the death of her cat. In fact, she wrote a poem: "A Lament on the Topic of Buttons McFlufferton." Lamentably, Silda is a very bad poet.
lampoon	(noun, verb)	A harsh satire (noun); ridicule or satirize (verb)	"As a Democrat," said Bob, "I can't say I appreciated watching that comedian in the Obama mask lampoon the State of the Union address."
landmark	(noun, adj)	Object (such as a building) that stands out and can be used to navigate by; a very important place, event, etc.	The Civil Rights Act of 1964 was a landmark in the battle for equality. / In Lebanon, many roads are unmarked, and people navigate by landmarks; for instance, follow the "third house down from the water tower."
languid	(adj)	Drooping from exhaustion, sluggish, slow; lacking in spirit	We signed up for a fitness boot camp, but after a single hour of exercise in the heat, we all felt so overcome with languor that we refused to go on. Turns out the reason we need a fitness boot camp in

			the first place is that we're pretty languid people.
lassitude	(noun)	Tiredness, weariness; lazy indifference	It's so difficult to get anything done in the dead heat of August! I can't seem to shake my lassitude enough to get out of this hammock, much less study for the GRE.
laudable	(adj)	Worthy of praise	When a major discount mart fired several employees for subduing a gunman, most people considered the action a laudable act of heroism, but the discount chain fired the employees for "violating company policies." Nevertheless, the mayor lauded the former employees in a medal-granting ceremony.
lavish	(adj, verb)	Abundant or giving in abundance; marked by excess (adj); give very generously (verb)	Anita wanted to live as she imagined Beyoncé lived, and ran up huge credit card bills pursuing a lavish lifestyle she could scarcely afford. / Although her rich banker boyfriend lavished gifts on her, she didn't want to be with someone she didn't really love.
layperson	(noun)	A person who is not a member of the clergy or not a member of a particular profession (such as	The actress Jenny McCarthy has written a book about autism. While her experience as a parent is interesting to anyone in a similar situation, it's still important to

		medicine, law, etc.)	remember that McCarthy is a layperson, not a doctor.
levity	(noun)	Lightness (of mind, spirit, or mood) or lack of seriousness, sometimes in an inappropriate way	My late uncle Bill loved practical jokes and absolutely would have approved of the iPod mix my aunt played at the wake, which added a little levity by segueing from “Amazing Grace” to the party anthem “Let's Get It Started.”
levy	(verb, noun)	Collect tax from, wage war on, or enlist for military service (verb); act of collecting tax or amount owed, or the drafting of troops into military service (noun)	When England levied yet another tax on the colonists, the colonists were pushed one further step towards levying war. Soon, the worried British began to raise troops by levy.
liberal	(adj, noun)	Favorable to progress or reform; believing in maximum possible individual freedom; tolerant, open-minded; generous (adj); a person with such beliefs or practices (noun)	Split pea soup benefits from a liberal application of pepper. / Liberal reformers in Egypt pushed for freedom of speech, freedom of the press, and freedom of assembly.
libertine	(noun)	Morally or sexually unrestrained person; freethinker (regarding religion)	A famed libertine, the sitcom star was constantly in the news for cavorting with women of dubious occupations and overdosing on drugs often enough to regularly hold up production

			of his popular television show.
likewise	(adverb)	Also, in addition to; similarly, in the same way	Chip was baffled by all the silverware set before him, so when his host began eating salad with the smallest, leftmost fork, Chip did likewise.
log	(verb, noun)	Keep a record of, write down; travel for or at a certain distance or speed (verb); a written record (noun)	Lawyers who bill by the hour have to be sure to log all the time they spend on every client's case. / You cannot get your pilot's license until you have logged 40 hours of flight time.
loquacious	(adj)	Talkative, wordy	The loquacious professor spoke at a million miles an hour and still regularly talked past the scheduled end time of the class.
lucid	(adj)	Clear, easy to understand; rational, sane, clear-headed	After surgery, it'll be at least an hour before she's lucid—it's nothing to worry about, but patients sometimes talk complete nonsense until the anesthesia wears off and their speech becomes lucid again.
lull	(noun, verb)	Soothe or cause to fall asleep (as in a lullaby); quiet down; make to feel secure, sometimes falsely (verb); a period of calm or quiet (noun)	Tisha always tried to be polite. If she had to slip out of class to use the bathroom, she waited for a lull in the action so as not to attract too much attention. / Grandma's singing lulled the baby to sleep—much as, in her work as a spy during World War II, Grandma used her beauty and

			charm to lull foreign dignitaries into giving up their secrets.
makeshift	(noun, adj)	A temporary, often improvised, substitute (noun); improvised for temporary use (adj)	Lost in the woods for over 24 hours, the children were eventually found sleeping under a makeshift tent made from branches and old plastic bags. / I don't have a ladder, but I can stack up some boxes as a makeshift.
malleable	(adj)	Able to be bent, shaped, or adapted	The more malleable the material, the easier it is to bend into jewelry—and the easier it is to damage that jewelry. / My mother is a little too malleable—she said she liked all the things her first husband liked, and now she says she likes all the things her second husband likes.
maverick	(noun)	Rebel, individualist, dissenter	Most cop movies feature heroes who are maverick police officers, breaking all the rules, blowing things up, and getting their guns confiscated by the chief, but who ultimately save the day.
mendacious	(adj)	Lying, habitually dishonest	She was so mendacious that, when she broke the television, she blamed it on her little brother, even though he was in a wheelchair and could hardly have tipped over a piece of furniture. Her

			mendacity knows no bounds!
mercurial	(adj)	Quickly and unpredictably changing moods; fickle, flighty	It's tough being married to someone so mercurial. One minute she's happy as a clam; the next, she's inexplicably depressed.
metamorphosis	(noun)	A complete change or transformation (in biology, a change such as a caterpillar becoming a pupa and then a butterfly)	Many reality show competitions are based on the idea of a contestant undergoing a metamorphosis, such as through dieting, exercise, life coaching, rehab, or plastic surgery—or all of the above.
meticulous	(adj)	Taking extreme care in regards to details; precise, fussy	As a surgeon, of course Mom needs to be highly meticulous in her work—she gets things right down to a fraction of a millimeter. But this also means that when it's her night to cook, she's sometimes a little too meticulous—no one really needs a meatloaf to be sculpted into an absolutely perfect rectangular prism.
mitigate	(verb)	Make less severe; lessen or moderate (damage, grief, pain, etc.)	Sadly, his illness could not be cured, but the nurses made every effort to mitigate the symptoms.
modest	(adj)	Humble; simple rather than showy; decent (esp. “covering up” in terms of dress); small, limited	The reporter was surprised that the celebrity lived in such a modest house, one that looked just like every other plain, two-story house on the block. / Her first job out of college was a rude awakening

			—her modest salary was barely enough for rent, much less going out and having fun.
mollify	(verb)	Calm or soothe (an angry person); lessen or soften	The cellular company's billing practices were so infuriating to customers that the customer service representatives spent every workday mollifying angry customers.
monotony	(noun)	Sameness or repetitiousness to the point of being boring; lack of variation, uniformity, esp. repetition in sound	The monotony of working on a factory assembly line made her feel as though she would go insane from boredom.
moreover	(adverb)	Besides; in addition to what was just stated	You are fired. Moreover, the police are coming to arrest you for theft.
mores	(noun)	Customs, manners, or morals of a particular group	An American in Saudi Arabia should study the culture beforehand so as to avoid violating deeply conservative cultural mores.
mundane	(adj)	Common, ordinary, everyday	Dominique had been excited to visit France for the first time, but she was soon disappointed at how mundane the stay with her relatives was: they shopped at the market, cooked dinner, chatted with one another, and occasionally went shopping.
naïve	(adj)	Simple and unsophisticated,	I was a little naïve during the hiring process—the Human

		unsuspecting, lacking worldly experience and critical judgment	Resources rep asked for my acceptable salary range, and I answered honestly. Of course, I got an offer for the very lowest number in the range! Now I know I should have tried to get a number from her first, or named a higher number so I could negotiate down.
nascent	(adj)	Coming into existence, still developing	The violin teacher was always very encouraging with children. All children sound terrible the first couple of years, so she offered plenty of praise to encourage nascent talents.
negate	(verb)	Deny or refute; make void or cause to be ineffective	Darling, if you add “I promise to try to work things out for at least a couple of weeks before giving up” to our wedding vows, it would kind of negate the part where you promise to love, honor, and cherish me “until death do us part.” / The debate coach reminded the students that they had to negate each one of their opponents’ major points in order to win.
net	(adj, verb)	Remaining after expenses or other factors have been deducted; ultimate (adj); to bring in as profit, or to catch as	In one day of trading, my portfolio went up \$10,000 and down \$8,000, for a net gain of \$2,000. / All those weeks of working weekends and playing golf with the boss

		in a net (verb)	ought to net her a promotion.
nevertheless or nonetheless	(adverb)	However, even so, despite that	While losing the P&G account was a serious blow, we nevertheless were able to achieve a new sales goal this month due to the tireless efforts of the sales team in bringing in three new clients. / I really can't stand working with you. Nonetheless, we're stuck on this project together and we're going to have to get along.
notoriety	(noun)	Ill fame; the state of being well-known for a disgraceful reason	Aiden was notorious for being late to everything; after awhile, his friends just stopped inviting him to the movies. / Some countries ban convicted criminals from capitalizing on their notoriety by writing books from prison or selling rights to movies about their lives.
novel	(adj)	New, fresh, original	You can make your writing better by eliminating clichés and replacing those clichés with more novel turns of speech. / Smoked salmon on a pizza? That's certainly a novel idea.
nuance	(noun)	A subtle difference in tone, meaning, expression, etc.	People with certain cognitive disabilities cannot understand the nuances of nonliteral speech. For instance, "You can come if you want to, but it's really going to be mostly

			family” means that you shouldn't try to come.
objective	(adj)	Factual, related to reality or physical objects; not influenced by emotions, unbiased	You cannot be forced to testify against your spouse in a court of law—it's pretty impossible for anyone to be objective about the guilt or innocence of a spouse. / Some philosophers argue that things like “love” and “guilt” don't exist, and that only objective reality—that is, physical matter—is of consequence.
obsequious	(adj)	Servile, very compliant, fawning	An obsequious assistant, Sammy thought he could get ahead by doing everything asked of him, but instead, his boss gave a promotion to someone he viewed as more of a peer; truthfully, he thought Sammy's sucking up was pretty pathetic.
obsolete	(adj)	Out of date, no longer in use	She kept her old laptop so long that it was obsolete—she couldn't sell it on Craigslist, and the local elementary school didn't even want it as a donation. / When you look up a word in the dictionary and see “Archaic” next to a definition, that means that definition is obsolete—people don't use the word that way anymore, although you might want to know that meaning if you're reading old texts.

obstinate	(adj)	Stubborn or hard to control	It's difficult to get an obstinate child to eat food he doesn't want to eat. When Toby realized that his son would rather sit and starve than eat mahi-mahi, he gave in and made him a peanut butter and jelly sandwich.
obviate	(verb)	Prevent, eliminate, or make unnecessary	Adding protective heel taps to your dress shoes can obviate the need to take them to the shoe repair store later, once the heels have worn down.
occult	(noun, adj, verb)	The supernatural (noun); pertaining to magic, astrology, etc.; mysterious, secret or hidden (adj); to hide, to shut off from view (verb)	A group of religious parents demanded that a popular series of young adult vampire novels be banned in schools because it promoted the occult. / During a solar eclipse, the moon occults the sun, and it is momentarily dark in the middle of the day.
offhand	(adj)	Casual, informal; done without preparation or forethought; rude in a short way, brusque	I was pretty happy with my salary until my coworker Deena mentioned offhandedly that she was thinking about buying a house now that she made six figures.
officious	(adj)	Excessively eager in giving unwanted advice or intruding where one is not wanted; meddlesome, pushy	Natasha's dinner parties are exhausting. She's an officious host who butts in and runs everyone's conversations, keeps an eye on what everyone is eating, and makes sure you finish your

			vegetables, and even knocks on the bathroom door to make sure you're "okay in there."
offset	(verb, noun)	Counteract, compensate for (verb); a counterbalance (noun)	Property taxes did go up this year, but the hit to our finances was offset by a reduction in fees paid to our homeowners association.
onerous	(adj)	Burdensome, oppressive, hard to endure	Doctors are often faced with the onerous task of telling waiting families that their loved one has died.
opaque	(adj)	Not translucent; not allowing light, heat, etc. to pass through; dark, dull, unclear, or stupid	The school dress code required opaque tights under skirts; the rules specified that sheer stockings were unacceptable. / Rena was tragically opaque. When her boyfriend said "I want to see other people," she thought he meant he needed glasses.
optimal or optimum	(adj)	Best, most desirable or favorable	Many believe that the U.S. Constitution's genius lies in its striking an optimal balance between freedom and order.
orthodox	(adj)	Adhering to a traditional, established faith, or to anything customary or commonly accepted	I appreciate that the new dentist thinks that my oral health can be improved through yoga, but I really prefer a more orthodox approach to dental care.
oscillate	(verb)	Swing back and forth; waver, change one's mind	I wish we had air conditioning, but at least I replaced our old fan with this oscillating one that swings side to side and blows air on

			the whole room. / Stop oscillating and pick a restaurant! Seriously—Indian or Thai?
outstrip	(verb)	Surpass, exceed; be larger or better than; leave behind	Our sales figures this quarter have outstripped those of any other quarter in the company's history.
overshadow	(verb)	Cast a shadow over, darken; dominate, make to seem less important	She was a straight-A student who excelled at field hockey, but she still felt overshadowed by her older sister, who won a national science competition for her work on cancer in mice, and also had time to become a pole vaulting champion and model who walked in Fashion Week.
paradigm	(noun)	Model or pattern; worldview, set of shared assumptions, values, etc.	Far from being atypically bawdy, this limerick is a paradigm of the form—nearly all of them rely on off-color jokes.
paradox	(noun)	Contradiction, or seeming contradiction that is actually true	Kayla was always bothering the youth minister with her paradoxes, like “If God is all-powerful, can He make a burrito so big He can't eat it?”
pariah	(noun)	Social outcast, untouchable	After the schoolteacher was fired for participating in what some called a “hate rally,” he became a pariah in his own town—even his longtime barber refused him a haircut.
partial	(adj)	Biased, prejudiced,	Although I grew up in New

		favoring one over others; having a special liking for something or someone (usually partial to)	York, I've always been partial to country music. / His lawyers are appealing on the grounds that the judge was partial to the plaintiff, even playing golf with the plaintiff during the trial.
partisan	(adj, noun)	Devoted to a particular group, cause, etc. (adj.); fervent supporter of a group, party, idea, etc.; guerilla fighter (noun)	It is unconscionable to engage in partisan politics in a time of crisis. People are trapped in the rubble of an earthquake, and you suggest that we vote for your tax bill in exchange for your voting for our relief bill?
patent	(adj, noun)	Obvious, apparent, plain to see (adj); a letter from a government guaranteeing an inventor the rights to his or her invention (noun)	Her résumé was full of patent lies: anyone could check to see that she had never been president of UNICEF.
pathological	(adj)	Relating to or caused by disease; relating to compulsive bad behavior	She thought her skin darkening was simply a result of the sun, but it was actually pathological, the result of a serious disease. / I can't believe you stole from the Make a Wish Foundation—you're a pathological thief!
patronizing	(adj)	Condescending, having a superior manner, treating as an inferior	I'm not surprised that Professor McDougal used to teach kindergarten. His patronizing tone has been driving me crazy.

paucity	(noun)	Scarcity, the state of being small in number	Our school has such a disgraceful paucity of textbooks that the students are sharing, and so cannot even count on being able to take the books home to do homework.
peccadillo	(noun)	Small sin or fault	I'm going to propose to Melinda tomorrow—sure, she has her peccadillos, like anyone, but she's the perfect woman for me.
pedestrian	(adj)	Ordinary, dull, commonplace	It was so amazing when you had us over to dinner and made that rack of lamb! I'm afraid neither of us is a professional chef like you are, though, so we hope you won't mind that we've made something more pedestrian: hot dogs and French fries.
penchant	(noun)	Liking or inclination (usually penchant for)	He seems like a mild-mannered accountant, but twice a year he jets off to Australia to satisfy his penchant for adventure sports.
perfidious	(adj)	Disloyal, treacherous, violating one's trust	The perfidious soldier sold out his comrades, giving secrets to the enemy in exchange for money and protection.
peripheral	(adj)	Relating to or making up an outer boundary or region; not of primary importance, fringe	My main goal is to get into a good grad school. Whether it has good fitness facilities is really a peripheral concern.
permeate	(verb)	Spread or penetrate	Under the Emperor

		throughout	Constantine, Christianity began to permeate every sector of public life.
pervasive	(adj)	Tending to spread throughout	Poverty is pervasive in our school system; 65% of students receive free or reduced-price lunch.
philanthropy	(noun)	Efforts to improve the well-being of humankind, generally through giving money	Many wealthy people turn to philanthropy as a way to create social good, and many others turn to it as a way to hobnob with the rich and famous.
phony	(adj)	Fake, counterfeit; insincere, not genuine	Phony Louis Vuitton bags are easily purchased in Chinatown, but they are illegal—selling them can land a vendor in jail, and the counterfeit bags are often made with child labor. / She's such a phony person, pretending to befriend people and then talking about them behind their backs.
pious	(adj)	Devout; religiously reverent and dutiful	Some matrimonial websites catering to conservative religious groups contain listings for young women that feature testimonials from a woman's relatives about her piety. Naturally, only similarly pious suitors need apply.
pith	(noun)	Core, essence; significance or	I can only stay at this meeting for a minute—can you get to

		weight	the pith of the issue now, and discuss the details after I leave? / This presentation has no pith—there's no central point and nothing I didn't already know.
placate	(verb)	Satisfy or calm down (an angry or dissatisfied person), esp. by conciliatory gestures	“It's an interesting business model,” said the flower shop owner. “Outside of Valentine's Day, our average customer uses our product to placate an angry partner.”
placid	(adj)	Peaceful, calm, tranquil	Famed Spanish tenor Placido Domingo has an unusual name—literally it means, “Peaceful Sunday.” It's certainly not a coincidence that <i>Placido</i> looks so much like <i>placid</i> .
plastic	(adj)	Able to be shaped or formed; easily influenced	A young child's mind is quite plastic, and exposure to violent movies and video games can have a much greater effect on children than they typically do on adults.
plausible	(noun)	Believable; having the appearance of truth	When three doctors treating crash victims were suddenly stricken with what looked like the effects of nerve gas, hospital officials posited “hysteria” as the culprit—hardly a plausible explanation, as emergency room doctors are accustomed to seeing horrific things every day.
plummet	(verb)	Plunge, fall straight	During the first 60 seconds or

		down	so of a skydive, the diver plummets towards Earth in freefall; then, he or she activates a parachute and floats down at what seems like a relatively leisurely pace.
polarized	(adj)	Divided into sharply opposed groups	The school board was used to rationally discussing issues, but when it came to the teaching of evolution in schools, the board was polarized, immediately splitting into two camps, with the discussion devolving into a shouting match within minutes.
ponderous	(adj)	Heavy; bulky and unwieldy; dull, labored	The book assigned by her professor was a ponderous tome, more a reference book than something you could read straight through. She was so bored she thought she would die.
posthumous	(adj)	Happening or continuing after death	Ernest Hemingway died in 1961. His novel <i>The Garden of Eden</i> was published posthumously in 1986.
potentate	(noun)	Ruler, person of great power	At 62 year's old, Prince Charles has certainly waited long enough to become potentate of England; his mother, Elizabeth II, has been ruling for his entire life.
pragmatic	(adj)	Practical; dealing with actual facts	Megan and Dave were in love, but Megan decided to be

		and reality	pragmatic—she doubted they'd stay together through a four-year long distance relationship as they attended different colleges, so she figured they might as well end things now.
preamble	(noun)	Introductory statement, preface	The Preamble to the Constitution is a brief introduction that begins, “We the People of the United States, in Order to form a more perfect Union...” / The unusual outfit the pop star wore to her first awards ceremony was a mere preamble to a career of full-blown crazy dressing.
precarious	(adj)	Unstable, insecure, dangerous	Recognizing that his position at the company was precarious, Sanjay requested that his bonus structure be formally written down as a contract, rather than dangled over him as a mere verbal promise.
precursor	(noun)	Something that comes before, esp. something that also announces or suggests something on its way	We cannot ignore this warning sign—it is clearly a precursor of larger problems to come. / The new CEO decided to do things differently from his precursors.
predisposed	(adj)	Having an inclination or tendency	Some autoimmune disorders don't kill the patient directly, but rather predispose the

		beforehand; susceptible	patient to other, potentially fatal illnesses. / His defense attorney argued that his abusive childhood predisposed him to a life of crime.
preempt	(verb)	Prevent; take the place of, supplant; take before someone else can	The speaker attempted to preempt an excessively long Q&A session by handing out a “Frequently Asked Questions” packet at the beginning of the seminar.
presumptive	(adj)	Based on inference or assumption; providing reasonable grounds for belief	The dictator's favorite nephew is the presumptive heir to power, but anything could happen. / He's the presumptive winner of the election; we haven't counted all the votes, but at this point it's almost mathematically impossible for the other guy to win.
presumptuous	(adj)	Too bold or forward; going beyond that which is proper	I would never date that presumptuous jerk! I mean, I thought he was attractive until he walked up to me and said, “We should go out—I looked up your address on Google and I'll pick you up at 8.” The nerve!
pretentious	(adj)	Claiming or demanding a position of importance or dignity, esp. when	Josie found her date's habit of constantly dropping French phrases into conversation to be incredibly pretentious, especially since he knew she

		unjustified; showing off, creating a deceptive, false show of worth	didn't speak French. He sure did sound fancy, though.
principled	(adj)	Having high moral standards	Donna was only an intern, but she was also quite principled —although she knew it would kill her shot at a full-time job, she was the one who alerted the authorities when asked to violate federal law via corrupt accounting practices.
pristine	(adj)	In an original, pure state; uncorrupted	Having grown up in a rural area, Billy had been in plenty of forests where people regularly left beer cans and shotgun shells behind. So it truly took his breath away, after hiking hours through the Himalayas, to visit a pristine forest, seemingly untouched by humans.
probity	(noun)	Honesty, integrity	After losing the last election when its candidate's string of mistresses came to light, the party vowed to only nominate candidates whose probity was beyond any doubt.
prodigal	(adj)	Wasteful, extravagant; giving abundantly, lavish	If you're going to leave a trust fund for your children, you should raise them not to be prodigal, or they'll blow through all the cash the minute they get their hands on it. / The prodigal land

			produced larger crops than the people could even consume.
prodigious	(adj)	Extraordinarily large, impressive, etc.	The Great Wall of China consists of a prodigious series of fortifications stretching over 5,000 miles. / If we don't double our sales with this new product, we will have to declare bankruptcy—we have a prodigious task ahead.
profligate	(adj)	Completely and shamelessly immoral, or extremely wasteful	The billionaire software developer was so disgusted with his profligate daughter's spending that he cut her off—she had bought champagne for an entire nightclub full of strangers one too many times.
profound	(adj)	Very insightful, penetrating deeply into a subject; pervasive, intense, “down to the very bottom”; at the very bottom	The philosopher's work was difficult to parse, but profound; it said truly novel things about the nature of reality. / He was profoundly disappointed when the project he had worked on for 15 years failed.
profuse	(adj)	Abundant, extravagant, giving or given freely	It didn't mean anything at all to me, giving my old microwave to the family next door, but the woman's profuse thanks made me think that maybe the family was having some financial troubles. / She came home on Valentine's Day to an apartment decorated with a profusion of flowers.
prohibitive	(adj)	Tending to forbid	I was admitted to NYU, but it

		something, or serving to prevent something	was prohibitively expensive, so I ended up at state school instead. / My parents installed a high fence as a prohibitive barrier against the neighborhood hooligans.
proliferate	(verb)	Increase or spread rapidly or excessively	The book alleged that terrorist cells are proliferating across the United States faster than law enforcement can keep up.
prologue	(noun)	Introductory part to a book, play, etc.	The novel's prologue gives some historical background so that the main story can be better understood in context.
pronounced	(adj)	Distinct, strong, clearly indicated	Aunt Shirley claimed we would never know that her “secret recipe” for brownies involved lots of healthy vegetables, but the brownies had a pronounced asparagus flavor.
propriety	(noun)	Conforming to good manners or appropriate behavior; justness	The parent questioned the propriety of the punishment meted out to her son—sitting in a corner all day seemed a little harsh for using the pencil sharpener at the wrong time. / Saying the accounting firm was complicit in “financial impropriety” was a rather polite way to refer to the fraud it committed against its investors.
prosaic	(adj)	Dull, ordinary	Finding his friends’ bar mitzvahs at the local

			synagogue a bit prosaic, Justin instead asked his dad to rent out the local laser tag center.
proscribe	(verb)	Prohibit, outlaw; denounce; exile or banish	Plagiarism is proscribed by every college's code of conduct.
prospective	(adj)	Potential, in the future	Everyone had a hard time correctly saying the name of the seminar, "Perspectives for Prospective Doctors." Even the prospective doctors—college students hoping to be admitted to medical school—were a bit confused.
prudent	(adj)	Wise in practical matters, carefully providing for the future	Sophie's friends blew all kinds of money on spring break, but Sophie prudently kept to her usual spending habits.
pugnacious	(adj)	Inclined to fight, combative	Maria had hoped to avoid inviting Uncle Luigi to the wedding, as he was a pugnacious fellow. Sure enough, he managed to start a fistfight with the best man.
qualified	(adj)	Modified, limited, conditional on something else	The scientist gave her qualified endorsement to the book, pointing out that, while it posed a credible theory, more research was still needed before the theory could be applied.
quandary	(noun)	Uncertainty or confusion about what to do, dilemma	He knew it sounded like the plot of a cheesy movie, but he really had accidentally asked two girls to the prom, and now he was in quite a quandary.

quibble	(verb)	Make trivial arguments or criticisms, find faults in a petty way, esp. to evade something more important	Look, I am telling you some of the serious consequences of global warming, as predicted by the scientific establishment—I think you're just quibbling to complain that I said “carbon monoxide” when I meant “carbon dioxide.”
quotidian	(adj)	Daily; everyday, ordinary	He was so involved in his quest for spiritual enlightenment that he regularly forgot more quotidian concerns—sure, he meditated for six hours a day, but he would forget to do laundry for weeks!
ranks	(noun)	Personnel; a group of people considered all together	Among the ranks of our alumni are two senators and many famous authors.
reap	(verb)	Harvest, such as by cutting; gather; get as a result of one's effort	He worked night and day in the strange new country, never stopping to rest, for he knew he would reap his reward when his family greeted him as a hero for all the money he had sent back home.
recluse	(noun)	Person who lives in seclusion	That show about “hoarders” featured a recluse who hadn't left her house in six years.
refute	(verb)	Prove to be false	She's not a very valuable member of the debate team, actually—she loves making speeches, but she's not very good at refuting opponents'

			arguments.
relegate	(verb)	Send or commit to an inferior place, rank, condition, etc.; exile, banish; assign (a task) to someone else	After the legal associate offended one of the partners, he found himself relegated to working on minor—even unwinnable—cases. / This protest is occurring because we refuse to be relegated to the fringes of society—we demand full inclusion!
remedial	(adj)	Providing a remedy, curative; correcting a deficient skill	After harassment occurs in the workplace, it is important that the company take remedial action right away, warning or firing the offender as appropriate, and making sure the complainant's concerns are addressed. / For those who need remedial reading help, we offer a summer school program that aims to help students read at grade level.
render	(verb)	Give, submit, surrender; translate; declare formally; cause to become	When you render your past due payments, we will turn your phone back on. / Only in her second year of Japanese, she was unable to render the classic poem into English. / The judge rendered a verdict that rendered us speechless.
replete	(adj)	Supplied in abundance, filled, gorged (used with <i>with</i>)	This essay is replete with errors—I don't think you even bothered to use spellcheck.
reproach	(noun,	Blame, disgrace	I'm not really enjoying my

	(verb)	(noun); criticize, express disappointment in (verb)	foreign study program. My host mom reproached me in Spanish; it sounded really harsh, but I couldn't really understand her, and I have no idea what I did wrong!
repudiate	(verb)	Reject, cast off, deny that something has authority	If you receive an erroneous notice from a collections agency, you have 30 days to repudiate the debt by mail. / As part of becoming an American citizen, Mr. Lee repudiated his former citizenship.
requite	(verb)	Reciprocate, repay, or revenge	Ashley felt that her unrequited love for George would surely kill her. George barely noticed her—he cared about nothing but requiting his father's death.
rescind	(verb)	Annul, repeal, make void	The governor rescinded his proclamation making September 10th “Pastafarian Day” once someone told him it wasn't a real religion.
resolution	(noun)	The quality of being firmly determined; resolving to do something; a formal judgment, esp. decided by a vote	The city government passed a resolution to support the new monorail. / A few setbacks did not dampen her resolution to complete her Ph.D.
resolve	(verb, noun)	Find a solution to; firmly decide to do something; decide by formal vote	She was resolved to find a marrow donor for her son, and led a stunningly successful drive to get people to sign up

		(verb); firmness of purpose (noun)	for a national donor registry. Even when no match was found for her son in the first year, her resolve was undampened.
respectively	(adverb)	In the order given	His poems “An Ode to the Blossoms of Sheffield” and “An Entreaty to Ladies All Too Prim” were written in 1756 and 1758, respectively.
restive	(adj)	Restless; Impatient or uneasy under the control of another	The company was purchased by a larger competitor, and the employees grew restive as the new bosses curtailed their freedoms and put a hold on their projects.
reticent	(adj)	Not talking much; private (of a person), restrained, reserved	She figured that, to rise to the top, it was best to be reticent about her personal life; thus, even her closest colleagues were left speculating at the water cooler about whether her growing belly actually indicated a pregnancy she simply declined to mention to anyone.
retrospective	(adj, noun)	Looking to the past or backward; applying to the past, retroactive (adj); an art exhibit of an artist's work over a long period of time (noun)	The proposed law is retrospective: anyone who violated the law before the law even existed can be prosecuted.
reverent	(adj)	Feeling or	Ayn Rand is a controversial

		expressing very deep respect and awe	figure, but critical views are not welcome at the local Objectivist Club meeting, where everyone expresses a reverent view of the author.
rhetoric	(noun)	The art or study of persuasion through speaking or writing; language that is elaborate or pretentious but actually empty, meaning little	The ancient Greeks used to study rhetoric as a major academic subject. Today, if you want to improve your rhetorical skills, you will probably have to hunt down a public speaking class or join Toastmasters. / The politician's blather is all rhetoric and no substance.
rife	(adj)	Happening frequently, abundant, currently being reported	Reports of financial corruption are rife.
rudimentary	(adj)	Elementary, relating to the basics; undeveloped, primitive	My knowledge of Chinese is quite rudimentary—I get the idea of characters, and I can order food, but I really can't read this document you've just given me.
rustic	(adj, noun)	Relating to country life, unsophisticated; primitive; made of rough wood (adj); a rural or uncultured person (noun)	For their honeymoon, they eschewed fancy hotels and instead chose a rustic cabin in the woods. / Grandpa was a true rustic—I was happy to have him visit, but not so happy to find him urinating outside in a bucket when we have several perfectly nice bathrooms.
sacrosanct	(adj)	Sacred, inviolable,	In our house, family dinners

		not to be trespassed on or violated; above any criticism	were sacrosanct—if being in the school play meant you would miss dinner, then you just couldn't be in the school play.
sagacious	(adj)	Wise; showing good judgment and foresight	It's important to choose a mentor who is not only successful, but also sagacious—plenty of people are successful through luck and have little insight about how to attack someone else's situation.
salubrious	(adj)	Healthful, promoting health	After spending her twenties smoking and drinking, Jessica recognized the necessity of adopting a more salubrious lifestyle, but found it difficult to cut back.
sanction	(noun, verb)	Permission or approval, something that gives support or authority to something else (noun); to allow, confirm, ratify (verb); a legal action by one or more countries against another country to get it to comply (noun); to place sanctions or penalties on (verb)	Professional boxers may only fight in sanctioned matches—fighting outside the ring is prohibited. / America's sanctions on Cuba mean that it is illegal for Americans to do business with Cuban companies.

sanguine	(adj)	Cheerfully optimistic, hopeful; reddish, ruddy (as in rosy-red cheeks indicting health or vitality)	She had three papers due in three days, but she maintained her typically sanguine attitude. "Things always just work out for me," she said, happily.
sap	(noun, verb)	The inner fluid of a plant or any essential body fluid; energy, vitality; a person taken advantage of (noun); undermine, weaken, tire out (verb)	I really thought that if I clicked on that Facebook ad and entered all my information, I would get a free iPad to test and keep! I feel like such a sap. / In order to make maple syrup, you must drain sap from a sugar maple tree. They call this "sapping" the tree, which I can understand, because I feel pretty sapped doing it! It's tiring work.
satiate or sate	(verb)	To fully satisfy; to go beyond satisfying to the point of excess (possibly inducing disgust, tiredness, etc.)	I usually just eat a tiny salad or something while I'm at work, but since I had a half day off, I went to the Indian buffet and stayed for a whole hour! I've never been more satiated (or sated) in my life. / To maintain a healthy weight, stop eating before you reach the point of satiety.
saturate	(verb)	Soak or imbue thoroughly; cause a substance to unite with the greatest possible amount of another substance	We got married on a rainy beach, and my dress was saturated. Although the pictures were a bit dark, the photographer was able to increase the saturation in Photoshop, making our

			wedding photos ultimately look quite vivid. / I simply cannot dissolve any more sugar into this iced tea—it's saturated!
savor	(noun, verb)	A characteristic taste or flavor (usually pleasant) (noun); appreciate fully, taste or smell with pleasure (verb)	As a parent, it's important to take a step back and really savor the special moments—those children will grow up sooner than you think!
scant	(adj)	Not enough or barely enough	The new intern was scant help at the conference—he disappeared all day to smoke and didn't seem to realize that he was there to assist his coworkers. / The soldiers were always on the verge of hunger, complaining about their scanty rations.
scathing	(adj)	Severe, injurious; bitterly harsh or critical (as a remark)	The school superintendant gave a scathing criticism of the education bill, calling it “an attack on our community's children that will surely go down in infamy.” / How is it possible that she flew off her bicycle like that and walked away unscathed?
secular	(adj)	Not religious or holy; pertaining to worldly things	Forty years ago, American companies wished their employees “Merry Christmas”—even the employees who didn't celebrate Christmas. Today, the secular phrase “Happy

			Holidays” is common. / Western governments have grown increasingly secular over the last century; many have laws prohibiting religious expression from being sponsored by the government.
sedulous	(adj)	Persevering, persistent, diligent in one's efforts	Sedulous effort is necessary to improve your GRE verbal score—you need to study vocab in a serious way, nearly every day.
sentient	(adj)	Conscious; experiencing sensation or perceiving with the senses	Tia became a vegan because she refused to eat any sentient creature.
simultaneous	(adj)	At the same time	It is rare in a duel that the two shooters draw their guns simultaneously and both fire.
skeptic	(adj)	Person inclined to doubting or questioning generally accepted beliefs	I wish you'd be more of a skeptic—I can't believe you spent money on a pet psychic so we can “talk” to our dearly departed shih tzu. / Descartes was a great skeptic, famously declaring that we cannot truly be sure of anything except our own existence—hence, “I think, therefore I am.”
skirt	(verb)	Border, lie along the edge of, go around; evade	Melissa spent all of Thanksgiving skirting the issue of whom she was dating and when she might get married and make her mother

			a grandmother. She was exhausted changing the subject two dozen times! / The creek skirts our property on the west, so it's easy to tell where our farm ends.
slack	(adj, verb, noun)	Loose, negligent, lazy, weak (adj); neglect to do one's duties; loosen up, relax (verb); period of little work (noun)	As the product of slack parenting, I never learned good time management skills —Mom and Dad never checked my homework or made me go to bed at a certain time. / The holidays represent an opportunity for employees to slack a bit.
slew	(noun)	A large number or quantity	As soon as we switched software packages, we encountered a whole slew of problems.
slight	(adj, verb, noun)	Small, not very important, slender or delicate (adj); treat as though not very important; snub, ignore (verb); an act of treating in this way, a discourtesy (noun)	She was very sensitive, always holding a grudge against her coworkers for a variety of slights, both real and imagined. / Actress Natalie Portman has always been slight, but she became even thinner to portray a ballerina in the movie <i>Black Swan</i> . / I felt slighted when my husband told you about his promotion before he told me.
solicitous	(adj)	Concerned or anxious (about another person), expressing care;	A solicitous host, Derek not only asked each person how he or she was doing, but asked by name about everyone's

		eager or desirous; very careful	spouses and kids. / Solicitous of fame, she would do anything to get near celebrities.
soporific	(adj, noun)	Causing sleep; sleepy, drowsy (adj); something that causes sleep (noun)	I was excited to take a class with Professor Baria because I had enjoyed her books, but sadly, she is a better writer than speaker—her lectures are soporific. / I was so distressed after the crash that the doctor gave me a soporific and, sure enough, I was able to think more clearly after sleeping.
sound	(verb)	Measure the depth of (usually of water) as with a sounding line; penetrate and discover the meaning of, understand (usually as sound the depths)	The psychiatrist appointed by the court felt he would need more time to sound the depths of the defendant's tortured mind; clearly, she was mentally ill, but did she know on any level that what she was doing was wrong?
spartan	(adj)	Very disciplined and stern; frugal, living simply, austere; suggestive of the ancient Spartans	A young soldier in the spartan environment of boot camp can really long for a home-cooked meal or even just a comfortable couch to sit on. / Her apartment was so spartan that she couldn't even serve us both soup—she only had one bowl and one spoon. Instead, we sat in hard-backed chairs and drank water.
spate	(noun)	Sudden outpouring	After a brief spate of post-

		or rush; flood	exam partying, Lola is ready for classes to begin again. / He was so furious that a spate of expletives just flew out of his mouth.
spearhead	(verb)	Be the leader of	Lisa agreed to spearhead the “healthy office” initiative, and was instrumental in installing two treadmills and getting healthy food stocked in the vending machines.
specious	(adj)	Seemingly true but actually false; deceptively attractive	“All squares are rectangles, all candy bars are rectangles, therefore all squares are candy bars” is clearly a specious argument.
spectrum	(noun)	A broad range of nevertheless related qualities or ideas, esp. those that overlap to create a continuous series (as in a color spectrum, where each color blends into the next in a continuous way)	A test showed she was partially colorblind—she did see blues and greens, but was unable to perceive some other colors on the spectrum. / A “dialect continuum” is a spectrum of dialects of a language where speakers in different dialect groups can understand some, but not all, of the other groups; for instance, people in the west can understand people in the middle, and people in the middle can understand people in the east, but people in the west and the east cannot talk to one another.
speculate	(verb)	Contemplate; make a guess or educated	During the Gold Rush, speculators bought up land,

		guess about; engage in a risky business transaction, gamble	sometimes with borrowed funds, expecting to prospect the land for gold and get rich quickly. / She speculated that, in zero gravity, showers would have to exist as closed rooms in which a giant bubble of water formed, and a person got inside it.
sporadic	(adj)	Occasional, happening irregularly or in scattered locations	Her attendance was sporadic at best, so when she flounced into class after a two-session absence, she discovered that not only was everyone working on group projects, but that the professor hadn't even thought to assign her to a group. / "Be seeing you." "Yeah, I hope not sporadically."
sportive	(adj)	Playful, merry, joking around, done "in sport" (rather than intended seriously)	After Will shot a ball entirely off the pool table, knocking a woman's purse off a bar stool, his friends laughed hysterically and called him "purse-snatcher" all night, but he took it as sportive and bought the next round of drinks.
standing	(noun, adj)	Status, rank, reputation (noun); existing indefinitely, not movable (adj)	As he had feared, his divorce greatly reduced his standing as a relationship expert. / I'm disappointed that you don't want to leave your current job, but I want you to know that

			you have a standing invitation—as long as I'm the boss, you have a job here anytime you want one. / While the U.S. has a standing army (that is, an army that is not disbanded in times of peace), Costa Rica's constitution actually forbids a standing military.
stark	(adj)	Complete, total, utter; harsh or grim; extremely simple, severe, blunt, or plain	The designer's work is appreciated for its stark beauty, but most people prefer to live in a cozier, more welcoming home—the kind with carpets and pillows, for instance. / She is stark raving mad! / The stark reality is that we will have to begin burning our furniture for warmth if we are to survive.
static	(adj)	Fixed, not moving or changing, lacking vitality	The anthropologist studied a society in the Amazon that had been deliberately static for hundreds of years—the fiercely proud people disdained change, and viewed all new ideas as inferior to the way of life they had always practiced.
status quo	(noun)	Existing state or condition	Many opposed the establishment of a needle-exchange program, but others reasoned that the plan would be an improvement on the status quo, in which disease spread rapidly through certain

			communities.
stingy	(adj)	Not generous with money, reluctant to spend or give	Billionaire industrialist J. Paul Getty was so famously stingy that he installed pay phones in his mansion for guests to use. When his grandson was kidnapped, he refused to pay ransom and only changed his mind when the kidnappers cut off the boy's ear. This famous cheapskate then demanded that his son (the boy's father) pay him back! What a miser.
stoic or stoical	(adj, noun)	Indifferent to pleasure or pain, enduring without complaint; person indifferent to pleasure or pain (noun)	Della was not only calm but positively stoic, facing the measles vaccination without a single yelp, in spite of her terrible fear of needles.
stolid	(adj)	Unemotional, showing little emotion, not easily moved	Dad is so stolid that we can't get a rise out of him no matter what we do—Jody got a tattoo, Max declared himself a communist, and Helen won a Rhodes Scholarship. No response! Dad just nodded and said “Alright, then.”
stymie or stymy	(verb, noun)	Block, hinder, or thwart (verb); an obstacle (noun)	Celine feared that her learning disability would stymie her success in college, but the support services offered were excellent, and she was fine academically; the thing that really stymied her college career was poor time

			management.
subjective	(adj)	Existing in the mind or relating to one's own thoughts, opinions, emotions, etc.; personal, individual, based on feelings	Naturally, anyone's experience of a movie is subjective, and some will enjoy this picture despite its flaws; however, it is an objective fact that the cinematography is very bad. / We can give names to colors, but we can never quite convey the subjective experience of them—what if my “red” is different from your “red”?
subside	(verb)	Sink, settle down, become less active; return to a normal level	When her terror subsided, she realized that the house wasn't really haunted. / It is a chronic illness—symptoms will flare up and subside over one's lifetime.
substantiate	(verb)	Support with evidence or proof; give a material existence to	You say you were at home when the crime occurred two towns over—is there anyone who can substantiate your claim? / Your business ideas are interesting, but you never substantiate them—you haven't put a single plan into action.
succeeding	(adj)	Coming after or following	After the sale of the company, you will receive 5% of the profits from the current year, and 1% in all succeeding years. / In 1797, George Washington was succeeded by John Adams.
supersede	(verb)	Replace, take the	Of course, electric washing

		position of, cause to be disregarded as void or obsolete	machines superseded hand-powered ones many decades ago, but my great-grandmother used her hand-cranked washer until she died in the 1990s.
supplicate	(verb)	Pray humbly; ask, beg, or seek in a humble way	She had been estranged from her wealthy father for years, but when she needed money for her daughter's medical care, she supplicated the old man for assistance.
surfeit	(noun)	Excess, excessive amount, overindulgence	The soup kitchen would like to announce that it has a serious surfeit of those cans of jellied cranberries that no one seems to want, but it could still use at least 10 Thanksgiving turkeys.
surmise	(verb)	Guess, infer, opine	Based on your rather sad attempt to figure out the tip on our restaurant bill, I would surmise that you actually have no idea how percents work.
sycophant	(noun)	Servile flatterer, toady	Stop being such a sycophant. I don't need you to compliment my tie or get me coffee; I just need you to do your job without bothering me.
synchronous	(adj)	Happening at the same time; occurring at the same rate and thus happening together repeatedly	The sound of that bell is a signal for the dancers to make perfectly synchronous entrances from opposite sides of the stage. / The two nearby churches have synchronous

			church bells—if you stand halfway between the buildings as the bells chime out the hour, it sounds really cool!
table	(verb)	Lay aside to discuss later, often as a way to postpone discussion indefinitely	I see we're not going to agree on whether to scrap our entire curriculum and develop a new one, so let's table that discussion and move on to voting on the budget.
tacit	(adj)	Understood without being said; implied, not stated directly	Her parents never told her she could smoke, but they gave their tacit consent when they didn't say anything about the obvious smell coming from her bedroom.
taciturn	(adj)	Not talking much, reserved; silent, holding back in conversation	Because he felt self-conscious about his stutter, Mike had always been taciturn, but after some very good speech therapy, soon he was much more voluble.
tangential	(adj)	Only slightly relevant, going off-topic	It's hard to get a quick answer out of Noah—ask him any question, and you'll get a wide range of tangential remarks before he gets around to the point.
temperance	(noun)	Moderation, self-control, esp. regarding alcohol or other desires or pleasures; total abstinence from alcohol	After the end of the Civil War, economic change led to an increase in alcohol problems and the birth of the Temperance Movement, which ultimately led to Prohibition. / Grandma is a model of temperance—she

			drinks red wine every night, but only the one-third of a glass that she read was conducive to preventing heart attacks.
tenuous	(adj)	Flimsy, having little substance; long and thin, slender	Your argument is quite tenuous—it depends on our accepting the results of a 1955 study published in an obscure medical journal not subject to peer review.
timely	(adj)	Well-timed, happening at a suitable time	Your arrival is quite timely—we were just mulling over a question we're sure you can answer. / His timely departure prevented him from having to do any work.
timorous	(adj)	Fearful, timid	The expression describing a timorous person as “quaking in his boots” is a bit of a cliché.
tirade	(noun)	Bitter, abusive criticism or verbal attack	I hate that television show where that commentator goes on angry tirades about all the liberal conspiracies taking over America. Even my conservative friends find his ranting embarrassing.
torpor	(noun)	Sluggishness, lethargy, or apathy; a period of inactivity	Sam had hoped to be able to play in the game after having his wisdom teeth out, but the anesthesia left him in such torpor that he obviously couldn't play soccer.
torrid	(adj)	Very hot, parching,	They had a torrid love affair

		burning; passionate	in the '80s, but split up because a royal was not permitted to marry a commoner. / The wandering refugees were in serious danger of becoming quickly dehydrated in the torrid Sahara.
tractable	(adj)	Easily controlled or managed, docile; easily shaped or molded	He's a tractable fellow; when I asked if we could see a different movie than the one we'd come to see, he shrugged and said "Cool." / The clay had hardened overnight, but adding water made it tractable again.
transitory	(adj)	Temporary, short-lived, not lasting	While a few people marry their high school sweethearts, generally, our teenage years are full of transitory relationships.
trifling or trifle	(adj, noun)	Trivial, not very important; so small as to be unimportant; frivolous, shallow	Luis broke up with Cara because she was always obsessed with some trifling matter—he tried to talk about foreign aid dependency, and she changed the subject to what the actress Katie Holmes dressed her daughter Suri in for a shopping trip. / The young heiress was so wealthy that she considered the salary from her internship a mere trifle, and didn't even notice when her paycheck was days late.
trite	(adj)	Lacking freshness	The topic of your speech is

		and originality, lacking effectiveness due to overuse, cliché	“Children Are the Future”? That's pretty trite. Maybe you should think harder and come up with something original.
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ubiquitous	(adj)	Existing everywhere at the same time	Pay phones, which used to be ubiquitous in urban areas, are now nearly impossible to find in operation. / Butterflies seem to be ubiquitous in the habitat; watch any surface for several minutes, and a butterfly is sure to alight on it.
undermine	(verb)	Weaken, cause to collapse by digging away at the foundation (of a building or an argument); injure or attack in a secretive or underhanded way	Rather than searching impartially for the truth, these pharmaceutical company “scientists” willfully ignored any evidence that undermined the conclusion they were being paid to produce. / You are nice to my face, but you are undermining me behind my back, suggesting to others in the office that I am making mistakes in my work and that you have been fixing them.
underscore	(verb)	Emphasize (or, literally, to underline text)	“You're not going to mess with Otto anymore,” said Otto. His new bodyguards stepped forward threateningly, as though to underscore his point.
unearth	(verb)	Dig up, uncover, expose	The ACLU's Prison Project works tirelessly to unearth evidence from old cases that might exonerate

			innocent people who have spent years or even decades in prison. / The archaeologist unearthed what appears to be the world's oldest known gravesite, showing that the earliest humans cared for their deceased loved ones.
unequivocal	(adj)	Unambiguous, clear, absolute; having only one possible meaning	Although Chuck denied he had a problem, his family was unequivocal in demanding that he check into rehab. Chuck knew there was no getting around it this time. / Jorge equivocated, going back and forth on the issue, but his brother Rafael was unequivocal—he knew what he wanted and went and got it.
unprecedented	(adj)	Never before known or seen, without having happened previously	When Nixon resigned, American bravado was at an all-time low—the resignation of a sitting President was disgraceful and unprecedented.
unseemly	(adj)	Improper, inappropriate, against the rules of taste or politeness	The activist really did want to get the candidate's support for the equal-rights measure, so she did what the candidate's aides asked, but she found it very unseemly that they suggested a specific dollar

			amount for the “donation” she was asked to make in order to get a meeting.
vacillate	(verb)	Waver in one's mind or opinions, be indecisive	In need of a good used car, I was vacillating between the Ford and the Hyundai until a recommendation from a friend helped me decide.
venerate	(verb)	Revere, regard with deep respect and awe	The boys were utterly crushed when the baseball player they venerated saw them waiting and refused to sign an autograph.
veracity	(noun)	Truthfulness, accuracy; habitual adherence to the truth	I question the veracity of your story. I just don't think you've been to outer space. / She was known for her veracity only because she had no choice—she was a terrible liar.
verbose	(adj)	Wordy	Twitter's 140-character limit really forces the verbose to go against their natural tendencies and instead write succinctly.
viable	(adj)	Capable of living (or growing, developing, etc.); practical, workable	I have three screenplay ideas, but the studio head said only one was commercially viable. Apparently, it's important to have a human lead character and a satisfying ending. / Due to leaps forward in technology, premature babies are

			considered viable earlier and earlier—currently around 24 weeks.
vintage	(adj, noun)	Related to items of high quality from a previous era, old-fashioned, antique (adj); the wine of a particular year (noun)	He didn't want just <i>any</i> vintage Darth Vader action figure—he wanted a particular vintage, the 1978 telescoping lightsaber one. / She special-ordered her favorite vintage of the Côtes du Rhône, then turned to her George Clooney–lookalike husband and joked that she liked men of a certain vintage as well.
virtual	(adj)	Existing only in the mind or by means of a computer network; existing in results or in essence but not officially or in name	The Tamagotchi is a handheld virtual pet made in Japan. You have to “care” for it by performing various actions with the device, but in the end, your “pet” still looks very much like a keychain.
vituperate	(verb)	Verbally abuse, rebuke or criticize harshly	All couples fight, but your girlfriend vituperates you so severely that I'm not sure she loves you at all. Verbal abuse is actually a pretty good reason to break up.
volatile	(adj)	Varying, inconstant, fleeting; tending to violence, explosive	Following the sudden revolution, the political environment in the country was so volatile that anything could have started

			a riot. / Stock prices are by nature volatile. If you want a “safe and steady” investment, try mutual funds.
warranted	(adj)	Justified, authorized (warrant can mean to justify or a justification, but can also mean to vouch for or guarantee)	The pundit's comments don't even warrant a response from our organization—they were mere name-calling, not suitable for public discourse. / Your criticism of Anne is unwarranted; as your assistant, she has done everything you've asked her to do. / He doesn't have his documents with him, but I'll warrant that he is indeed a certified forklift operator.
wary	(adj)	Watchful, motivated by caution, on guard against danger	Be wary of anyone who tells you that “anyone” can get rich with some special plan or scheme.
whereas	(conjunction)	While on the contrary, considering that	Mr. Katsoulas had always assumed his son would take over the family business, whereas his son had always assumed he would go away to college and never come back. / Whereas peppers and squash are technically fruits, they are typically considered vegetables for culinary purposes.
whimsical	(adj)	Marked or motivated by	<i>Alice in Wonderland</i> is a famously whimsical story

		whims (odd, fanciful ideas); erratic, unpredictable	in which a little girl falls down a rabbit hole and finds a strange and at times absurd world. / She enjoyed a whimsical day at the seashore—no plan, just wandering around and making sand castles as the mood struck.
wily or wiles	(adj, noun)	Crafty, cunning, characterized by tricks or artifice	The wily criminal stole eight laptops by simply walking into a branch of a large company, introducing himself as the laptop repairman, and waiting for people to hand him their computers. / She was quite offended when her coworker suggested that she use her “feminine wiles” to make the sale.
zeal	(noun)	Great fervor or enthusiasm for a cause, person, etc.; tireless diligence in furthering that cause; passion, ardor	Whether you agree with their views or not, you have to admit that the employees of PETA have great zeal for animal rights—most work for less than \$25,000 a year, and often participate in protests that get them shouted at or even arrested.
zenith	(noun)	High point, culmination	At the zenith of her career, the actress could command \$5 million per film. Now, she is mostly seen in made-for-TV movies.